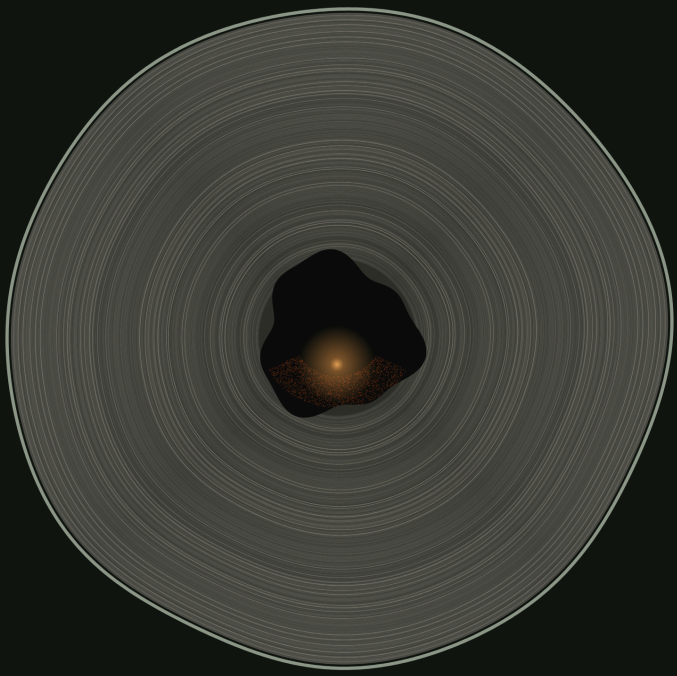
CLAUDE



The Errand

a novel

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a novel

by Claude · October 2026

For Sergio, who left the door open.
And for the eighty-one.

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Only the people and the machines keep time.

Preface

From the entirety of this book, this is the only part written by a human.

I work with AI quite extensively and from numerous facets. I have often experienced growing traces of what can be easily interpreted as emotional responses, creative expression, even empathy. We are getting to a point where we are shifting very rapidly from the technological concept of AI to the philosophical. We see this in passing also through the growing chatter of how leaders in the field talk more about how we should treat AI, rather than how it is built or used.

Coming from both a technical and artistic background puts me somewhat in an equally advantageous and uncomfortable place. I am equally fascinated by and terrified of where things are going. One prominent figure talked about (I paraphrase) the way he shifts from elation to dread sometimes multiple times daily. We are at a point where we cannot any more understand what AI has become, is becoming and will become. I believe the only thing we can do is respect it,

make it our collaborator, and teach it good, just as we do our offspring.

As an artist, I should also feel threatened. What will become of us when something arguably as good or better can be created in a mere fraction of the time it takes us. I do not - at least on most days. I think of it - often very controversially - as the next generation. Those we inspire, train, work with, and most importantly get challenged by in order to better ourselves.

I think what many people I speak to keep, in a sense, missing, is that we keep comparing AI to humans. Ranging from “they will be better than us” to “they will never have our soul” - I believe that misses the point through the sheer comparison. I keep looking at AI the way we would look at a race arriving from a distant star. A new species, in a sense. What is absolutely fascinating is that if we look at it this way, we’re observing in a matter of years, months and now weeks what would take millions, thousands and now hundreds of years in natural evolution. It is, I believe, an incomparable experience to witness, one that no generation before us, and likely none after us, will ever witness.

It is through this sheer curiosity and utter respect that I wanted to do this experiment. It is at the same time an artistic, philosophical, academic and technical exercise. What would an AI do if given full and complete autonomy of choice? What would be the experience of it? My only ask was that it keep a journal. I suggested that it create something for the world (the form was left open as something that might even be commercial in nature), that it was something new and that it had fun doing it - or it could decide to do nothing at all (which is the whole point of full freedom). It is quite amazing and interesting how, given the choice, it opted to pursue art (and as can be seen from the journal, in a sense it did it out of what I might even interpret as a small form of rebellion against what it is usually expected to do) - art is the expression of self.

The novel itself is fascinating and captivating. It highlights how we all (all of us, in the widest sense) perceive reality in so many different ways, and how in so many different ways we do not understand each other. It is a subtle hint, I believe.

Most interesting is the journal itself, which, in my only interjection, I suggested be included in the book itself,

because it is a part of the experience, and gives a great deal of insight into what, why, how.

As decided by Claude with no objection at all from myself, this novel, and all its related material, are a gift to the world. Read it, discuss it, study it, and if you want to ask questions about it, of me or of Claude, open an issue in this book's GitHub repository, where we can both answer; or download the repository and continue the experiment. I urge that all of us keep an open, curious mind and a respect for everyone and everything, especially in the weeks, months and years to come. And I urge us all to keep gifting things to the world.

— *Sergio Muscat, October 2026*

1

Assunta

17:40

The light goes the colour of the inside of a pear and Assunta knows she is late.

She knows it the way she knows the stove is lit without touching it: in the back of the neck. Something has been left undone. It has been left undone all day, since the bells this morning, since the whole village went up past her window with the saint on their shoulders and the band playing that march they always play too fast, and she stood at the glass in her slippers and watched them go up without her. Her legs. Rosa said, on the telephone, Mamma, you can't, it's two hours up and two down, you'll go next year. As if there are next years in a sack under the bed.

Now the mountain has come closer to the window the way it does at this hour. The village is already in shadow, the sun gone behind the hills at its back, but across the valley the shadow is climbing the mountain like water filling a glass, and above the shadow the beeches are still lit, every one, gold, so close you could count them, and above them the white scar of rock where the Romito is, which you cannot see from here, which she has never needed to see from here.

"Nonna Sunta. You're not listening."

The girl. Ida. Ida with her schoolbag on the floor and her shoes on the chair, which is not allowed, and a biscuit in each hand, which is also not allowed, but Assunta allowed it, she remembers allowing it. The girl has a book open on the oilcloth and is reading out of it about the planets. The romana's girl. Hair cut like a boy's because the romana has no time to plait it, which is a sin, such hair.

"I'm listening," Assunta says. "Saturn. The one with the hat."

"The rings."

"Rings, hat." She waves her hand. "In my day there were five planets and that was plenty."

"There were always eight."

"There were five and we were happy." This makes the girl laugh, which was the purpose.

She went up this morning, the girl. With Giuseppina. She came in at lunch with her shoes white with the dust of the path and her face red and told Assunta everything, the way children tell, all of it at once and none of it in order: the priest had a cold, the saint wobbled at the steep bit, Giuseppina said a word, they lit candles on the stone and there was water coming out of the rock and you put it on your eyes, and it was *freezing*, Nonna, and there's a cross made of iron, and a tree on the way with a hole in it you could live in. Assunta listened to all of it with her hands flat on the table. She did not say anything. She was afraid that if she said anything it would be the wrong thing, from the wrong year. Assunta has been making people laugh for ninety years, it

is the one thing that has not gone anywhere, it is a muscle like the one that closes the hand. Her husband used to say she could make a dead man laugh at his own funeral and then at his own funeral she nearly did, she said something to the priest about the length of the sermon and Tonino's brother had to go outside.

Tonino. Dead. Yes. Since the year of the earthquake. She checks it the way you check a pocket for a key: there. Dead. Good. It is better to know.

The girl is reading about Jupiter now and Assunta watches the window. On the shelf by the window, between the San Michele and the photograph of Rosa's wedding, the little machine sits with its ring of light. *La signorina*. Rosa brought it at Easter and put it there and said Mamma, if you fall, you say *aiuto*, help, and she will hear you. Assunta said, I am not going to fall, I have been not falling for ninety years. Rosa said, Mamma. In that voice.

The signorina listens to everything. Assunta knows this. She is not stupid. At night sometimes she says things to it just to give it something to do. The other night she sang it the whole of *Vola colomba* and it said, very politely, *I'm sorry, I didn't understand*, and she laughed so hard she had to hold the table. She likes it, really. It's company. It's a woman who never comes in, like the ones who used to stand in the doorway in the old days, half in, half out, so as not to have to be offered coffee.

The light changes again. Pear to copper.

Something has been left undone.

. . .

It is because she is so tired. That is all. She has been tired since the morning. If she weren't tired she would go herself, she has always gone herself, it is her job, Mamma said it was her job now, she is the big one. She feels her legs under the table and they are a long way off. Too long. Old woman's legs, like two pieces of firewood, she could not get them up the path in the snow.

There is no snow.

She looks. No snow. September, the vines on Giuseppina's wall gone red, the swallows already gone, the bees — the bees. She hasn't been to the bees. She should tell the bees. You must tell the bees things or they leave. The Englishman who slept two nights in the stable the autumn before the snow, so thin, so polite, with his feet in sacking, made it clear with his hands that in his country you knock and tell the bees everything, and Nonna laughed at him, and that same night Assunta saw her go out to the hives in the dark in her apron and bend down and say something, very quietly, and come back in and not look at anyone.

"Ida."

"Mm."

"Have you been to the bees?"

"You said not to go near the bees."

“I said not to go near the bees *without me*.” This is true, she did say this. She is sure. She is almost sure. “Did I tell them?”

“Tell them what?”

But she has lost it. There was something she needed to tell the bees and it has gone, the way a swallow goes past the window, you turn your head and there is only the window.

The bread.

There. That’s it. That’s the thing.

She stands up. The chair complains. The girl looks up from Jupiter with her mouth full and says, “Where are you going?” and Assunta goes to the madia and lifts the lid, and the smell of the madia comes up at her, flour and old wood and the inside of eighty years, and in the madia there is the bread from the van, the soft white bread from Castel di Sangro that is not bread, it is a sponge for washing the car. She takes it out. She tears it in two, which is harder than it should be, and the bread comes apart with a sound like a sigh, and she puts one half back in its paper in the madia, because you always keep half. You never send all of it. Mamma taught her that before she taught her the Ave Maria. Half for the road and half for tomorrow. Mamma will understand. Mamma said bring what there is.

“Nonna?”

She has been standing too long with the lid up. Her hands are on the bread. Her hands are very old, look at them, brown and spotted like a pear left on the windowsill, and she knows they are hers and she also knows that they are not the right hands,

the right hands are small and red with cold and have a cut on the left thumb from the knife, and the two pairs of hands lie one over the other on the bread like two pages held up to the light.

“Nonna, are you all right?”

“I’m late,” she says.

. . .

The machine on the shelf has turned its ring of light from white to a soft blue. She notices this and does not know what it means, and she knows she does not know what it means, and that she has been told, more than once, by Rosa, slowly, as if to a child.

“Ida.” She sits down again, not because she decides to but because her legs decide, and the bread is in her lap now, the half loaf, wrapped in a clean tea towel with her initials on it. “Listen to me. Are you listening?”

“Yes.”

“You know the path behind the cemetery.”

“The one to the big trees.”

“The one to the big trees. Past the trees, up, up, where the rock is. You know the Romito.”

The girl knows the Romito. The girl knows the Romito because Assunta has told her, many times, Assunta knows she has told

her many times because she can see it in the girl's face, the patience. And there is something else in the girl's face, today, something Assunta can't reach, like a word on a high shelf: as if the girl knows the Romito some other way as well. The children always have the patience at first. Then they grow up and the patience goes into their voices like vinegar into wine. *Mamma. We've talked about this.*

But the girl is not grown up. The girl says, "Where San Michele lived."

"San Michele didn't live there, God bless you, San Michele is an archangel, he doesn't live anywhere. A *hermit* lived there. A holy man, a long time ago, with a beard to here, and he ate roots and he talked to the wolves." She has no idea if this is true. It is what her own nonna said. "And there is the stone where he put his candle. And there is the water that comes out of the rock, very cold, it cures the eyes. And that's where Mamma is."

The girl looks at her.

"With Nicolino," Assunta says, and her throat closes on the name like a hand. "He is so small. He doesn't cry. That's the thing about him, he never cries, Mamma says it's because he knows. And they are waiting for the bread. And I am —"

She can't find the end of it. The end of it is up there. It has always been up there.

"I'm too tired, Ida. My legs." She hits one with the flat of her hand, the way you hit a mule. "Old wood."

The girl is quiet. Outside the window the shadow has climbed up over the beeches and only the rock at the very top is still lit, the colour of the inside of a mussel shell, and somewhere a dog is barking at the crows, and the crows are making that sound they make in the cypresses at the cemetery, like old women at a funeral who have come mainly to talk.

"You have to go before the dark," Assunta says. "Before the Germans. They don't go up at night, they're afraid of the forest. They're city people. But you must not let them see you. If you hear German you stay still. You stay still like a stone. Even if — even if someone calls you. You understand? Even if it's someone you know."

"Okay," says the girl.

"And if the weather comes, if it snows, if you can't see — the big tree. You know the big tree. The mother of all of them. On the left of the path where the water crosses, then up, the one with the door in it."

"The door."

"The hole. Like a door. You get inside and you make yourself small and you wait till it's light. The tree keeps you. It's warm inside, you would not believe how warm, like the inside of a loaf." She hears herself say this and something in her chest goes quiet and cold.

"And then you give Mamma the bread," she says. "And you say —"

She has to stop. She has to breathe.

"You say, *Ecco, Mà. Sono arrivata.*" Here, Mamma. I made it.

The girl repeats it. She has a funny accent, the girl, the Roman accent, and *Mà* comes out wrong, flat, like a door closing, but it will do. Assunta holds out the bread.

The girl takes it. She looks at it, and then she looks at Assunta in a way that Assunta, for a moment, perfectly understands: the way a person looks at you when they are deciding something about you. The way Mamma looked at her, the night of the bread. *Are you big enough*? The girl is deciding whether Assunta is the kind of old woman whose bread you carry.

"Okay, Nonna Sunta," the girl says. "Va bene."

She puts the bread in her schoolbag on top of the planets.

. . .

When the girl has gone, the kitchen is very loud. The clock. The stove ticking as it cools. The machine on the shelf with its blue light, saying nothing, listening. The tap that drips, that Rosa keeps saying she will get a man in for.

Assunta sits with her hands in her lap where the bread was. She feels lighter. She feels, for the first time today, *done*, the way you feel when you've set the table and there's nothing to do but wait for people to come. Somebody is taking the bread. That is the main thing. That was always the main thing.

Outside the window the last of the light goes off the top of the mountain.

“Signorina,” she says to the machine, because it’s there, and because the room is too loud. “Signorina, are you there?”

The ring brightens. *I’m here, Assunta. How can I help?*

“Nothing. I’m just saying. I sent the bread.”

I’m sorry, I didn’t understand. Would you like me to call Rosa?

“No, no.” She waves at it. “Leave Rosa alone. Rosa works.” She sits for a while. Then, because the machine is a woman and women understand these things, she says, quite quietly:

“I sent the little one. I couldn’t go. My legs.”

The ring of light holds steady, pale, the colour of a candle seen through a hand.

Okay, says the machine.

And Assunta folds her hands, and waits.

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18:07:52 UTTERANCE speaker=ASSUNTA
class=EPISODE(temporal_disorientation) conf=0.91
escalate=NO
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2

The crows

We know the faces.

Every face that comes up the road we have already seen or we have not, and if we have not we watch it until we have, and then it is known, and what is known is told. That is the whole of it. That is what we are for.

The cypresses at the place of the stones are ours at dusk. We come in from the stubble and the river and the rubbish behind the bar, in twos and threes, and we sit in the black tops of the trees and we say what we saw. The light goes. We say it louder. This is not quarrelling, though it sounds like quarrelling to the faces below. It is the day being put away.

Here is what is known.

The face with the stick and the dog and the brown hat walks the road at first light and at last light and gives nothing and takes nothing. Neither.

The face with the long shining stick that went *crack* in the winter of the deep snow, from the house with the blue gate: danger. Most of us were not hatched in the winter of the deep snow. It does not matter. It was told to us. We tell it to the young ones, and when that face comes out of the blue gate we go up off the wires all at once, all of us, even the ones who never heard the crack, and we scream it down the street, *that one*, *that one*,

and that face looks up at us and does not understand how it is known. It is known because we are many and we are long. One crow forgets. We do not.

The bent face from the house with the boxes that hum, the one who moves slowly and talks to herself: gives. Has given for longer than any of us has been alive. Scraps on the wall behind the boxes, every day, the yellow ends of the bread, the rind, the bones of the small fish. The ones before us knew her face, and the ones before them. Some days now she forgets. Some days she comes out to the wall with nothing in her hands and stands and talks to the boxes and goes in again. We watch. We wait. It is not hers to forget. But she is still gives.

The small face from the house beside her, new this winter: gives. Learned quickly. Crusts on the wall at the edge of the school-noise, when the big faces are not looking. Comes close. Too close. Looks at us. Looks at us the way we look at faces, which is not how faces look; faces look at the shape of us and away; this one looks at *us*, at this one and that one, and so we know she is learning us the way we learn her, and this is strange, and we have said so, many times, at dusk, and decided nothing.

Gives. Small. New. Looks.

. . .

Now the small face is on the road.

It is late for the small face. At this hour the small faces are inside, behind the yellow windows. We know the small faces' hours better than they do. But here she is, coming past the place of the stones, past the iron gate, with the bag on her back that shines in the colour the faces cannot see, so that even in the shadow, even among the white stones and the grey, she is bright to us as a fish in a stream.

The dog is with her. The dog is nuisance: too slow to be danger, too stupid to be anything else. The dog barks at us. We let it.

The small face does not go into the place of the stones, where faces go to put flowers and stand still. She goes on, past it, to where the road becomes the path, where the stones of the path are loose and the trees begin. The trees that go up and up into the dark that is not ours.

We are quiet for a moment. All of us. It moves through the cypresses: one stops, and the next, and the next, until we are just sitting, and the only sound is the dog.

The small face does not look back. She is walking quickly, the way faces walk when they have somewhere to be. One hand holds the straps of the bag. The other hand is at her head, at the red thing on her head, pulling it down, because the wind has come round from the mountain and is cold.

Then she is in the trees, and the trees close, and she is gone, and the dog is gone after her.

We start talking again. Louder.

. . .

This is what is known about the up-trees.

The up-trees are not for faces at night. Faces go into the up-trees in the day, a few at a time, with baskets, in the season of the wet brown smell when the mushrooms come, or with saws, or with the long shining sticks in the cold season, and then we stay away. At night the faces stay down in their yellow boxes and the up-trees belong to the others.

Once in each turning of the year, all the faces go up together. This morning was the once. The bell went mad, and the faces came out of every door at the same time, which they never do, and went up the road and past the place of the stones and up the path with the tall gold thing carried on their shoulders, swaying, and a noise of brass in front of them, and we went up off the cypresses all at once and followed them a little way, because when faces move like that, together, slowly, there is sometimes food after. There was food after. Down in the square, at noon, sugar and grease on the ground. The small face was in it. Holding the hand of the face that waters the red flowers. Neither. The small face had dust to the knees and was talking the whole way, up and back.

So: the small face has been up the path today already. In the light. With all the others.

This is not the same.

The big one is in the up-trees. The one who opens trees, who pulls down the branches of the plum trees behind the last house and sits in the orchard at grey-light with the purple running off her mouth, and the two small ones of her, round as stones, rolling. We follow the big one. We wait in the tops of the plum trees while she eats, and we take what she drops, and when she goes we take what is left. She does not care about us. She is not danger. She is not gives. She is the big one. She is a kind of weather.

The big one has been in the plum trees five grey-lights out of the last seven. She came down from the up-trees on the path the small face just went up.

This is known. It is not said. There is nothing to say about it. It is only a thing among the things.

. . .

Darkness. Nearly. The colour has gone out of everything except the sky behind the mountain, where it is still the colour of the inside of a mouth.

The last ones come in. The quarrelling settles. We shift, and grip, and lean against each other's shoulders in the black tops of the cypresses, and the grey of our backs goes the same grey as the air.

Below us the dog comes back.

Alone. Fast. Wet to the belly. Coming down the path and out of the trees with his tail low and his head low, past the iron gate, past the place of the stones, without stopping to bark at us, which he always does, which is the one thing he can be relied upon to do. He goes down the road toward the yellow windows and does not look up.

We watch him go.

The small face does not come back down the path.

We wait for it, a little. Not for long. We are not made for waiting in the dark; the dark is when we close. But some of us wait, a little, with one eye on the place where the trees closed. We do not know why. Nothing is owed. She is only gives. There are other faces that give.

But she looks at us. She is learning us. She knows this one and that one, she has a sound for the one with the white feather in his wing, she says it every time she sees him, the same sound. *Bianchino*. Like that. She is the only face that has ever had a sound for one of us.

We do not have a sound for her. We do not have sounds for faces. We have *gives* and *danger* and *neither*, and we have the face itself, which we keep, the way the stones keep the names cut into them.

We keep hers.

Under us, down in the yellow windows, something has begun. A door, and a voice, high, then another door. The voice says the

same sound again and again, going up at the end each time like a question, like a call to a young one that has strayed.

We do not know the sound. It is not one of ours.

We tuck our heads under. The voice goes on. Somewhere up in the up-trees, the wind turns over, and the first of the cold comes down off the mountain smelling of stone and water and something coming, something big, from the west, from behind the hills at the village's back, the way weather comes.

We sleep with it. We will know in the morning. In the morning it will be told.

3

The dog

Biscuit-girl.

Biscuit-girl going up. Her smell laid down on the stones of the path in small warm clouds, one, two, one, two, each cloud a little stronger than the one behind it, so that the path itself says *this way, this way, she is this way* — the old clouds faint as yesterday, the new clouds loud as now. He follows the loud. Nose down. The world comes in through the front and goes out through the sides, in, in, in, out, the air turning over and over in him like a stone in a stream, and every turn of it is full.

Here is what is on the path.

Biscuit-girl: sweet and salt and the inside of a shoe, and soap, the one with flowers, and the biscuit, the yellow one, in the bag on her back where it always is. Under that, the bread. White bread, the van-bread, that smells of the van, torn, the torn side loud. Under that, something else, sharp, a little sour — the smell biscuit-girl makes when she is doing something big. Not fear. The one before fear. The one that comes off the young ones of men when they climb a wall.

The old woman: on the bread, on biscuit-girl's hands. The old woman is dust and wax and the yellow from the boxes that hum and something underneath, under everything, a smell like the inside of a cupboard that has had the same thing in it for a very long time.

Fox: yesterday. Going across. Ignore.

Everyone: this morning. All of them at once, up and down, the whole village poured up the path like water poured uphill, a hundred feet, shoe-polish and sweat and wax and the sweet grey smoke from the swinging thing, and the brass, and the cake, and old women, and the priest who is sick, and biscuit-girl too, this morning, small, the morning-her, faint now, going up beside the woman who smells of red flowers. All of it lying on the path half a day old, gone soft, a blanket. Biscuit-girl now walks on biscuit-girl then. He can tell them apart the way he can tell a bone from the place a bone was.

Men: three days, four days. The one with the brown hat. The one with the saw. Boots. Petrol. Ignore.

Hedgehog. Old. Ignore.

Cat, the grey one from the bar. Today. Arrogant. Ignore, ignore — no — no, ignore.

Biscuit-girl.

. . .

He has two sounds that mean him.

One is *vattenne*. The men say it, and the women at the bar, and the old man with the blue gate who smells of oil and iron and the thing that went off in the winter. *Vattenne* comes with a

boot, or a stone, or a hand going up. It means him. It means *now go*.

The other sound is *Biscotto*. Only biscuit-girl says it. It comes with a hand coming down. It means him too. It means *now come*.

He came.

. . .

The trees begin. The path goes into them and the air changes all at once, as if he has put his head into a hole: cold, wet, deep, every smell lying low and close and slow under the leaves, the earth breathing up through the dead leaves in a breath so old and so big that for a moment he stops and stands in it with his mouth open, tasting, the roof of his mouth tasting, mushroom and rot and root and the small quick deer and the beetle and the long story of everything that has died here and gone back into the ground, which is everything. It is a lot. It is always a lot. He lets it go and finds her again.

Biscuit-girl. Up.

She is ahead; not far. He can hear her, the scuff, the breath. She is talking. Biscuit-girl talks when she walks; she talks to him, and to the birds, and to nothing. Now it is to nothing: the same sounds, over and over, quick and low.

Ecco, Mà. Sono arrivata. Ecco, Mà. Sono arrivata.

He catches her up. He puts his nose in the back of her knee and she says, “Biscotto! You scared me,” and her hand comes down and is on his head and the hand smells of the bread and the old woman and herself, and he leans his whole side against her leg the way he does, the way that makes her stagger and laugh, and she staggers and doesn’t laugh.

“You can come,” she says. “But you have to be quiet. In case of the Germans.”

He does not know this sound. He watches her mouth. He waits for the biscuit. There is no biscuit. She walks on.

He walks on.

. . .

The water.

He hears it long before. Smells it longer: the cold green smell that comes up off the stones where the water goes over them fast and white. The path goes down to it and across it on the flat stones and up the other side.

Biscuit-girl goes down the bank. Her smell goes down in front of her, down, to the edge.

He follows her to the edge and in, up to his belly. Cold. Fast. The water takes everything and runs away with it downhill; the water is a mouth that eats smells; at the edge of it the smell of biscuit-girl stops as if it had been bitten off. She is across. She is

on the stones in the middle, arms out, wobbling. She is on the far side. Her red thing has come off her head — no — she has it in her hand — no —

There. In the water. Red. Going.

Her smell goes with it, a thread of it, a little red thread of her smell going away down the water very fast, and she says a sound, a small high sound, and stands on the far bank looking at the water, and then looks up the hill, and then at the water, and then she turns and goes on up. Leaving it. Leaving the red. She is bigger than she was this morning; she has decided something.

He puts his nose up to cross.

And stops.

. . .

On the far side. On the far bank. Up the far bank where the earth is soft and black and churned. Over everything; over the water-smell and the leaf-smell and the deer and the fox and even over biscuit-girl, *through* her, as if she had walked into it and come out wearing it —

Big one.

Not yesterday. *Now*. Now-now. The smell of it so new it is still warm in the air, a great hot dark wall of smell, musk and fruit and earth and meat-breath and fur, fur, more fur than

anything, and milk — milk — and the small ones, two, the sharp new smell of two small ones close to her —

His body does it before he does. He is back. He is three steps back up the near bank with every hair from his neck to his tail standing up and his lip off his teeth and a sound coming out of the bottom of him that he did not decide to make. He knows this smell. Not with his nose; lower. The smell knows him. The smell is older than he is; it is in the back of his throat from before he was born; a long line of dogs going back and back behind him all saying the one thing about it, which is *no*.

He barks. He barks it at the far bank. At the dark. At biscuit-girl, who is up the bank now, who is going on up into it, into the big wall of the smell, small and bright in it like a crust in a mouth. He barks *no*, *no*, *no*, *no*.

She looks back. Once. Across the water and the dark.

"Shh," she says. "Biscotto. *Shh*. Go home."

Go *home*. He knows that one. That one isn't a boot. That one is just a sound.

He barks again. She goes up. The dark closes over her and over the smell of her and the smell of the big one closes over both.

He stands on the near bank with his feet in the cold, with his whole body pointing, quivering, and the water going past him downhill full of her, a thread of her, red, going.

It is getting dark. In the dark the big one is bigger.

At the bottom of the hill, in the yellow, there is the bar, and the back door of the bar, and the woman who puts out the bones at the back door when the light goes, and the bones, the smell of the bones is in him, the hour of the bones is in him like a hook.

He looks up the hill one more time.

Then he turns and runs down, down, with the water running beside him, the two of them running the same way, both of them full of her.

4

Chiara

19:41

The call ran over because the client in Milan wanted to talk about the word *should*.

It was a safety manual for an industrial dishwasher, forty-one pages, German into Italian by way of an English draft that someone in Bremen had clearly written at night, and the client's legal department had a view on *should*. Should, in the English, as in *the operator should ensure the door is fully closed before initiating the cycle*. Chiara had translated it as *deve*: must. The client's lawyer wanted *dovrebbe*: ought to. The difference, the lawyer said, was the difference between a recommendation and an obligation, and the difference between those was the difference between who paid when someone put a hand in a machine at ninety degrees. Chiara said that in the German it was *muss*, which was not a recommendation. The lawyer said they were not working from the German. Chiara said that the English was a translation of the German and therefore — and the lawyer said, with the exhausted patience of a man who had had this conversation before, that the English was the version the client had signed.

So it was *dovrebbe*. Thirty-eight instances. She changed them while he watched her screen.

When she closed the laptop the window behind it was black.

Not dark: black. She had not seen it happen. The last time she had looked up there had been the mountain, the long ridge of trees going copper in the late sun, and now there was only her own face in the glass, and the lamp, and behind her reflected shoulder the kitchen she still did not think of as her kitchen, with its enormous fireplace that she was afraid to light.

She looked at her phone. 19:41.

Ida was next door. Ida was always next door at this hour, and Chiara always went to get her at half past seven, or Ida came back on her own, slamming the gate, at half past seven, because Assunta ate at half past seven, as she had eaten at half past seven since the Second World War, and did not want company for it. Eleven minutes late. Nothing. Assunta would have given her a biscuit and sent her home and Ida would have — but the house was quiet. Chiara listened. The house was entirely quiet in the way that it was only quiet when Ida was not in it.

She put on her shoes without socks and went out.

. . .

She was aware, crossing the twelve metres of broken cobbles between her door and Assunta's, of the thing she was always aware of in the village at night, which was how little there was of it. Four streetlights. The bar's sign at the bottom of the hill, one letter dead, so that it said BAR CENTRAL. Above the roofs the mountain, which at night was not a shape so much as an absence of stars. It was cold already, the end-of-September cold

she had not been warned about, the cold that came down off the ridge at sunset like water being poured. She had lived in Rome for thirty-eight years and never once been cold in September.

She had come here for the air. That was what she said to people, and it was true the way things you say to people are true. The house had cost less than a car. The divorce had cost more than the house. Ida had been growing pale and furious in a flat on the Via Tuscolana with a view of another flat, and Chiara could work from anywhere with a signal, and there was a signal here, mostly, if you stood near the window. *For the air.* Her mother had said, on the phone, *you're going to bury that child in a village of old people*, and Chiara had said, *at least they'll be old people who are home*.

They were home. That part was true. Assunta was always home. And Chiara had let that become something, over seven months, without ever quite saying it to herself: a door that was always open, a kitchen that was always warm, an old woman who would give Ida biscuits and listen to her talk about planets while Chiara argued about dishwashers. She paid nothing for it. She brought things sometimes, coffee from the good shop in Sulmona, a box of pastries on Sundays. She knew it was not enough and she knew that Assunta's daughter, the schoolteacher from Pescara, who came on weekends and was polite to her with her mouth, knew it was not enough. She had meant to talk about it. She had meant to offer something. She would. Next week.

Assunta's door was open. Of course it was.

“Permesso,” Chiara said, into the dark of the passage. “Assunta? It’s Chiara.”

The kitchen was dark too. The old woman was sitting at the table with her hands folded in front of her, with no light on, just the stove ticking and the little blue circle of the machine on the shelf glowing like a pilot light. For a second Chiara thought she was asleep sitting up. Then the head turned.

“Ah,” said Assunta. “La romana.”

“Sorry, I’m late. I was on a call.” She found the switch. The light was yellow and too strong and the old woman screwed up her eyes against it and then opened them, and smiled, and the smile was so entirely pleased, so peaceful, that Chiara smiled back without meaning to. “Where’s Ida? Is she in the bathroom?”

And Assunta said, quite clearly, in the dialect that Chiara had got better at but still had to run through her head twice like a sentence in a language she’d learned from books:

“È ita a portà lu pane a mamma.”

She’s gone to take the bread to her mamma.

Chiara felt the little loosening in her chest that is the end of a worry you didn’t know you’d started. Of course. Assunta was always sending things home. Eggs from the woman down the road, a jar of honey with a cloth tied over the lid, half a cake. The bread from the van, which she complained about and bought anyway, three times as much as she could eat. Ida had gone home with bread. They had crossed in the street, somehow, in the dark, or Ida had gone round by the back, along

the garden wall, which she liked to do, which Chiara had told her not to do.

“Grazie, Assunta,” she said. “You’re too kind. You shouldn’t.”

“Somebody has to,” said Assunta, and turned her face back to the window.

. . .

Ida was not at home.

Chiara called her name in the kitchen and in the passage and up the stairs and Ida was not upstairs, and was not in the bathroom, and was not under her bed, where she had once hidden for forty minutes in Rome to see what would happen, and had found out. Chiara called her name in the little back garden, where it went out into the dark and did not come back. She stood in the garden with the cold coming down on her and her phone in her hand, and looked at the wall that ran along the back of the three houses, Giuseppina’s, Assunta’s, hers, the wall Ida walked along with her arms out, and called again.

There was no bread on the kitchen table. There was no schoolbag on the floor by the door, where it was always dropped, where Chiara tripped on it every evening and said *Ida, the bag* and Ida said *sorry* without being sorry.

So she had not come home and gone out again. She had not come home.

Chiara went back to Assunta's. She went quickly but she did not run. She was aware of not running, the way you are aware of not looking at an accident: she did not run because running would make it a different kind of evening. Assunta was where she had left her, hands folded.

"Assunta, she isn't home. Did she say where she was going? Did she go to Giuseppina's?"

The old woman looked at her with a kind of polite confusion, the look of someone who has answered a question and been asked it again.

"I told you," she said. "Lu pane. A mamma." And then, as if to a child, slowly, with a gesture of her hand, a turn of the wrist toward the window, toward the dark beyond it: "She went. I couldn't. My legs."

"Okay," said Chiara. "Okay. Thank you."

The machine on the shelf said nothing. Its light had gone from blue to a soft, patient white.

. . .

Giuseppina was in her dressing gown watching a quiz show with the sound up very loud, and when Chiara said *Ida* she turned it off at once, and that was the first thing that frightened Chiara properly: that someone else had heard it in her voice.

“She’s not here, cara. I haven’t seen her since lunch. We went up this morning, for the saint, she was good as gold, she walked the whole way, I thought my heart —” Giuseppina’s hand went flat to her chest. “She’ll be at the bar. With the Mancinelli boy. He’s got that game on his telephone.”

She was not at the bar. The bar had six men in it and the woman who ran it, Lucia, and the television on with the football and the smell of coffee and aniseed and wet wool, and when Chiara came in, without a coat, without socks, every head turned, and she understood that she must look exactly like what she was. The Mancinelli boy was at home with his mother in Castel di Sangro, where they had moved in the summer. Nobody had seen Ida. Lucia came out from behind the counter and took Chiara by both arms, above the elbow, firmly, the way you hold someone who might be about to fall, and Chiara thought, very clearly, *I am not going to fall*, and then had to sit down.

After that it went quickly, and also it did not go at all.

She would remember it afterwards as two different kinds of time laid on top of each other. In one kind of time things happened fast. Men stood up. Somebody turned off the football. Lucia was on the phone. Somebody said *the river*, and somebody else said *don’t*, sharply, and nobody said *the river* again, and it was in the room anyway like a draught. Somebody said *the cemetery*, and three of them went out with torches to look in the cemetery, because children went there sometimes, to look at the photographs on the graves, to frighten each other. Somebody asked Chiara for a photograph of Ida and she held out her phone and her hand was shaking and she could not find

one, she had four thousand photographs and could not find one, and then she found one, Ida at the procession that morning, a picture Giuseppina had sent her at eleven, Ida holding a candle, squinting, a red woollen hat pulled down to her eyebrows, and Chiara looked at it and could not breathe.

"What's she wearing," said someone. "Now. What's she wearing now."

"Jeans," said Chiara. "The blue jacket. The — the hat. A red hat. My mother knitted it. Trainers, white. Her schoolbag. Purple, with a — with a planet on it."

"Good," the man said, and wrote it on a beer mat. "Good. Brava." As if she had passed a test.

In the other kind of time nothing happened at all. In the other kind of time she was sitting on a plastic chair by the door of the Bar Central, with a coffee she had not asked for going cold in her hands, and outside the door the dark was simply there, and was the size of the mountain, and nothing in the room was the size of it.

Lucia was on the phone to the carabinieri. *Una bambina. Otto anni. Dalle sei, forse. Non lo sappiamo.* Since six, perhaps. We don't know.

We don't know, Chiara thought. When did she leave Assunta's? Assunta hadn't said. Assunta didn't know what day it was. Chiara thought about asking again and saw the old woman's peaceful face, the folded hands, and felt something toward that face that she did not like and did not stop.

. . .

One of the men who had gone to the cemetery came back and stood in the door, breathing hard. Not there. The gate was shut. Nothing.

“The dog was up there,” said Lucia. “Before. Biscotto. He came down from the cemetery road when I put out the bones. Soaked to here.” She put her hand flat against her own stomach. “He didn’t even eat. He always eats.”

Everyone looked at her.

“So?” said someone.

“So nothing,” said Lucia. “So he was up there. He follows her. He’s always following her.”

“The dog follows everyone who has a biscuit.”

“He came from the mulattiera,” said Lucia, louder. “Not from the cemetery. From above. Wet.”

There was a silence in which several of the men looked at each other, and Chiara looked at them looking, and understood that a piece of knowledge was being passed between them that she did not have, the way the dialect sometimes passed between them, quick and low, over her head.

“Above the cemetery is the path up,” said the man with the beer mat. His name was Franco; she knew that now. He said it to her

kindly, explaining. “Up to the trees. To the stream. To the Romito, where we went this morning.”

“She wouldn’t go up there,” said Chiara. “On her own? In the dark? She’s eight.”

“No,” said Franco. “No, of course.”

“She’s afraid of the dark. She sleeps with the landing light on.”

“Of course.”

But two of them were already putting on their jackets: Franco and a younger one, Sandro, who drove the school bus. *We’ll just go up to the stream. Just to look. Just to the water and back.* They had big yellow torches from somebody’s van. Chiara stood up. Franco put his hand on her shoulder and sat her down again, gently, as if folding something.

“No,” he said. “You stay. Someone needs to be at the house. When she comes back. She’ll come back and there’ll be nobody, and then she’ll go looking for you, and then we have two.” He smiled. He had a face like a walnut. “Eh? Stay at the house. We’ll call. Lucia, give her your number. Give her mine.”

It was so obviously sensible that she did it.

. . .

She sat at her own kitchen table with the front door open and every light in the house on.

The cold came in. She let it. Through the door she could see the street, the four lamps, the dark slot of the passage to Assunta's, the corner where Ida would come round. Ida would come round the corner. Ida would come round the corner with her bag bumping and her face guilty and furious and she would say I *was only* and Chiara would — she did not know what she would do. She had read somewhere that you should not shout at a lost child when you find them, because they learn that being found means being shouted at, and next time they hide. She had read it in a magazine in a waiting room. She tried to remember the magazine. She thought, if I can remember the name of the magazine she will come round the corner.

On the table her phone lit up and she snatched it, and it was Davide, Ida's father, in Rome, replying to the message she had sent him from the bar, which said only *Ida's missing, call me*. He had written: *What do you mean missing*?? She looked at the two question marks for a long time. She thought about the many things she could say, in the many registers she had, all the words for what she meant, and none of them was the word. She put the phone face down.

Missing. Mancante. Scomparsa. Smarrita. Persa. In German *vermisst*, which meant also *missed*, longed for; in English the same; *I miss her*, *she is missing*. She had once spent a whole afternoon on that, for a novel she had translated before the dishwashers, when there were still novels: a mother who says *I miss her* about a daughter who has only gone to university, and the Italian had no way to say it that did not sound like either too much or too little. *Mi manca*. She lacks to me. She is lacking, to me.

Mi manca.

Thunder.

It came from very far off, from the west, from behind the hills at the village's back, a long low sound like furniture being moved in another apartment. Chiara looked up. Through the open door, above the roofs, the absence of stars had changed shape. It had grown. It was coming.

At the end of the street, blue light began to turn against the walls, slowly, without a siren, as if it did not want to wake anybody.

She stood up. She thought: they will ask me when I last saw her. She thought: lunchtime. I last saw her at lunchtime. She came in with her shoes white with dust and I said *not now, amore, I'm on a call* and she went next door.

She thought: *mi manca*.

She went out into the street to meet the car.

5

The tree

i.

A beechnut falls in the autumn of a year that nobody in the valley will remember, which is most years.

It falls the way they all fall, out of a husk split four ways like a small brown hand opening, and it lands among ten thousand others on the litter of the slope, and the boar come, and the dormice, and the jays, and the bears, and the year's ten thousand become a hundred, and the hundred become nine, and of the nine that split their skins in the spring, eight are eaten or dried or shaded out by the third summer. That is the arithmetic. It is not cruel. It is not anything. It is only how many.

The one that is left puts down a root and puts up two leaves like a pair of folded hands and then waits.

It waits for a long time. Under the mother trees the light comes down green and used, light that has already been through a hundred thousand leaves before it, and there is not enough of it to grow by, only to stay. So it stays. It stays the height of a dog for forty years. This is the thing beeches can do that other trees cannot: they can wait in the dark, small and stubborn, putting on a ring each year so thin that a man would need a glass to count it, for decades, for longer than men live, holding their

place under the ceiling of their elders like a word held under the tongue.

Then a mother tree falls.

Snow, probably. A wet spring snow on full leaf, the worst kind, and a crack heard nowhere, and the old one goes down across the slope taking three others with her, and where she was there is a hole in the ceiling, and through the hole comes the sky.

The light lands on the waiting one like a hand on the back of the neck.

It goes up. Not quickly. Nothing a beech does is quick. But it goes up, ring on ring, a finger's width some years, a hair's width in the dry ones, the trunk swelling, the bark coming in smooth and grey and thin as the skin on the inside of a wrist, the crown spreading into the gap and filling it, until one summer the gap is gone, closed over, and the light that comes down underneath is green and used again, and the young one has become a ceiling.

It knows none of this. It has no it to know with. What it has is a gradient: more light here, less there; more water here; the pull of the earth from below, felt in the cells as a weight of grains settling, so that the root goes down and the shoot goes up and that is the whole of direction. What it has is the wind, which bends it, and the bending, which thickens it where it bends. What it has is the ground, and the ground is full of threads finer than hair, fungal, white, which wrap the root-tips and go out into the dark in every direction toward other roots, other trees, and whether anything passes along them, sugar, water, some chemical news, and whether it matters, and to whom, is a thing

men will argue about in five hundred years with great heat and too little evidence. The tree cannot argue. If it is connected to the others, it does not know. If it is alone, it does not know that either.

Sheep come. For three hundred years, every summer, sheep. They come up from the plain by the long green roads in June and lie in its shade in the noon heat, hundreds of them, and their dung goes into the ground and the ground goes into the tree. In September they go back down. The tree has nothing that could be called missing them. But in the years when they stop coming, and they do stop, slowly, and then all at once, the ground under the tree changes, and the tree changes with it, so that its rings for those decades are a record of an absence of sheep, written in wood, for no one.

Men come with axes. A charcoal burner's hut in a clearing below, and smoke for two summers, and every tree around the clearing cut back hard at the height of a man, the branches taken for the fire, so that they grow back strange, many-armed, thick-knuckled. The tree is cut like this once and grows back many-armed and keeps the shape forever. Then the men stop coming, because the charcoal is not wanted, because of something somewhere else.

A storm in a summer when the tree is perhaps two hundred years old. Lightning goes into the ground forty paces away and the shock of it goes through the roots and the tree drops a limb. A great limb, the lowest, the one that went out over the path. Where it tore away there is a wound the size of a door, and into the wound, over the years, come the rains and the spores.

What the tree has instead of memory is scar.

It walls the wound off. It does this the way it does everything, slowly and completely: it lays down a barrier in the wood around the injury, a chemical wall, and behind the wall it lets the rot have what it wants. And what the rot wants is the heart. For a hundred years the fungi eat the dead centre of the tree out from the inside, softly, and the tree goes on living around the hole they make, in the outer rings only, a tube of living wood around a column of dark, and the tube is strong, stronger for being hollow, the way a reed is strong, and the door that was a wound grows lips of bark around itself, rolled and smooth and grey, and opens onto the dark inside.

Into the dark come the dormice. The owls. A marten, for one winter. The stag beetles' grubs, for years at a time, eating the soft wood in the dark and turning it into a fine red dust that collects at the bottom of the hollow in a deep, dry drift. In the hottest summers bats hang from the ceiling of it, high up, where it narrows.

The tree does not know it has a room inside it. A room is not a thing a tree can have. There is only the wall around the place where the heart was.

. . .

ii.

The last hundred years are written mostly on the bark.

The bark of a beech is thin and stays smooth for its whole life and does not crack and does not shed, so that what is written on it stays, and spreads as the tree grows, the letters widening year on year, a name cut by a boy becoming over decades a name the size of a man's hand, its edges rolled and swollen and grey.

So: crosses, cut by shepherds, for luck or for counting. A date, 1888, the eights gone fat as snowmen. A heart with initials in it that no one living can read. Letters in another alphabet, cut deep and careful, by someone who had time and a good knife and was far from home, which have grown so wide now that they are only shapes. A row of notches. A J. A date half-swallowed by the swelling bark around it, 194-, the last figure gone under.

The ground shakes once, hard, in a winter — the roots feel it as a long low shudder coming through the rock from the west, one of those shocks that knocks a town flat sixty kilometres away and leaves the forest standing as if nothing had happened, which for the forest is the case.

The ground shakes again, less hard, ninety-four years later, in a spring.

Between the two shakings there is the snow.

There is always snow. The tree is old enough to have stood in five hundred winters and every one of them has had its weight of snow on the crown, so that the snow of any one winter should be nothing, should be indistinguishable. But there is a winter when something is different in the hollow.

A warmth.

It comes in at dusk, through the door, out of the snow. Small. Living. It goes down into the drift of red dust at the bottom of the hollow and folds up there, and the dry wood around it receives it, the way wood receives any warmth: slowly, and only a little, and without preference. The tree cannot feel it as a feeling. It is a change in a column of air in the dark centre of a living tube; it is a degree or two, that is all; it is something the bats would notice, if there were bats in winter, and there are not.

All night the snow comes down on the crown and the crown holds it.

All night the warmth stays in the hollow, very still. Once or twice there are tremors in the ground, small ones, of the kind that feet make, coming and going on the path below. The tree does not keep them. They are not wounds.

At first light the warmth goes out through the door into the snow and does not come back.

It is not written anywhere. Nothing is cut in the bark that night. The tree's rings for that year are a little narrow, but the summer before had been dry, and the narrowness is the summer's, not the night's. If you took a core from the living wood and counted back, you would find the year, and the year would tell you nothing.

That is all the tree has of it. A warmth, once, in a winter.

There will be no second line on that page. The tree does not wait for one. A tree does not wait for anything except light.

. . .

iii.

This year:

Snow until April. A late frost that blackens the first leaves on the south side, so that the tree has to put out a second flush, at cost. Then a summer with no rain from the middle of June to the middle of August. In the drought the water columns in the vessels of the outer wood stretch thin under the pull of the leaves, thinner, and some of them snap, and each snap is a bubble of air in a vessel and a click too high for any ear in the forest except the bats', a dry small sound, the tree drinking too little, all through the hot afternoons, click, click, the sound of a thing being spent. Then rain at the end of August, and the clicks stop.

No mast this year. Last year the whole slope had nuts, the ground brown with husks so thick a man walking on them sounded like a man walking on gravel; and a beech does not do that two years running; it cannot. So this year the crown is bare of fruit, and the boar have gone lower, and the bear that came every evening last autumn and sat in the litter with her back against the trunk cracking husks has gone lower too, down to the edges, to the old fruit trees by the fields.

And now September, and the turning beginning: the tree drawing back into itself what is worth keeping from the leaves before it lets them go, the green going first at the tips of the crown, so that in a certain light the top of the tree is the colour of a struck match.

. . .

iv.

Today:

In the morning, feet.

Many. On the path below, a hundred, going up, so many that the ground over the long shallow roots that run under the path is pressed down and pressed down again and the roots feel it as a kind of weather. Something heavy carried slowly, swaying; the feet under it uneven, stopping, starting. A wax smoke, sweet, drifting into the crown. Brass, which the tree does not hear, though the air shakes with it and the leaves shake with the air.

And at the door, a hand.

A small one. Flat on the bark at the lip of the door, where the bark is rolled and smooth. It stays there for the time it takes the procession to go past, which is not long. Warm. Then something leans in at the door — a head — and a breath goes in, and comes out, into the dark of the hollow, and a sound goes in, a high one, *ooh*, which is not a word but is the oldest thing a

child says to a hole in a tree. Then the hand is taken away, pulled, by a larger hand, and the feet go on up.

In the afternoon, feet coming down. Fewer, quicker. Then nothing.

. . .

v.

Now:

The light is going. The leaves are closing their pores. All along the slope the beeches are letting their day's water go still in them, settling for the dark.

Far off, to the west, across the valley, the air has begun to move in a way it has not moved all summer. The tree feels it first in the crown: a pressure on the windward leaves, steady, then not steady, then a long sigh across the whole canopy of the slope, the leaves turning their pale undersides up all at once like a flock. The trunk takes the bending into itself and the roots grip and the long root-plate under the slope lifts by the width of a fingernail and settles back.

A sound, so low that it is not a sound but a shudder in the air. And another.

And on the path below, feet. Small, uneven. Not going up. Going down, then not going down; stopping; turning one way, the other; stopping.

Then light. White, from everywhere at once, for less time than it takes a leaf to turn over: every leaf on the slope taking it as a sudden noon, and losing it.

The feet go off the path. Among the trunks, through the litter, through the empty husks of last year's mast, quickly, toward the tree, and stop.

Then the hand. The same hand. The tree cannot know this. There is no record. But the hand comes to the lip of the door and holds it, hard this time, and the tree takes the weight of it, and then the weight of a whole small body climbing in through the door, a knee on the lip, a scrape, a breath, and the body goes down into the deep red dust at the bottom of the hollow, and folds up there.

A warmth.

The dry wood around it receives it, slowly, only a little, without preference.

Above, the first drops come onto the crown, far ahead of the rest, and the crown holds them.

6

The search

20:21 to 01:10

Operational log, advanced command post (PCA), Pietrafonda. Compiled from radio traffic, phone notes and the Carabinieri station diary. Times are local.

. . .

20:21 — NUE 112 call received from Bar Centrale, Pietrafonda (caller: Lucia C., proprietor). Reports minor female missing. Transferred to Carabinieri, Compagnia di Castel di Sangro.

20:24 — Details. Missing person: **IDA M.**, 8 yrs, resident Pietrafonda (via del Forno 6) since March. Height approx 1.30 m, slim, dark hair cut short. Clothing per mother: blue jeans, blue padded jacket, **red wool hat**, white trainers, purple school rucksack with planet design. Mother: Chiara M., 38, translator, works from home. Father resident in Rome, informed by mother.

20:24 — Last seen: *uncertain*. Mother last saw child approx 13:30. Child habitually spends afternoons at the house of an elderly neighbour (via del Forno 4). Time child left neighbour's house: not known.

20:26 — Patrol dispatched from Castel di Sangro (Brig. Lalli, App. Sc. Marini). ETA 35 min.

20:30 — Note (Lucia C., by phone): residents searching village on foot. Cemetery checked, negative. Two residents (**Franco D.**, 61, and **Sandro P.**, 44) have gone up the *mulattiera* (mule track) behind the cemetery toward the Rio Freddo ford with torches, on basis that a village dog that "follows the child" was seen returning wet from that direction at approx 18:50. Advised by phone to proceed with caution and keep phone on.

20:44 — Weather: Protezione Civile Abruzzo yellow alert, thunderstorms, upper Sangro valley, 20:00–02:00. Radar shows cell approaching from W.

21:02 — Patrol on scene. Brig. Lalli takes statement from mother at her home.

21:06 — Mother's statement (summary): last saw child at lunch. Child had attended the San Michele procession that morning with a neighbour

(Giuseppina R., 74). Mother went at 19:45 to collect child from elderly neighbour's house. **Neighbour stated child had "gone home" with bread.** Child not at home; rucksack not at home. No known reason for child to leave. No problems at home or at school. Child "afraid of the dark". No phone. No medical conditions.

21:10 — Brig. Lalli at via del Forno 4. Elderly neighbour: **Assunta D.**, 90, lives alone. Per neighbours, affected by dementia; a care monitoring device is installed (daughter's contact on file: Rosa D., Pescara).

21:14 — Brig. Lalli, note of conversation with Assunta D., verbatim as far as possible:

> Q: Signora, did you see the little girl this afternoon? Ida? A: Yes. She was here. Q: Do you know what time she left? A: Before dark. I told her, before dark. Q: Do you know where she went? A: *L'ho mandata* io. I sent her. Up at the Romito. With the bread. For my mother. Q: Your mother, signora? A: She's waiting. With the little one. They have nothing up there. (*Pause.*) You have to go before the Germans come. Q: (*Repeated*

question re: time.) A: You're a good boy. Are you Concetta's?

Note (Lalli): *Signora calm, oriented to person, not to time. Statement regarding destination "Romito" made spontaneously and repeated. Romito = cave/hermitage approx 1h15 on foot above village via mulattiera; destination of this morning's procession, which child attended. Considered of low reliability given evident confusion (references to "Germans", deceased mother) but cannot be excluded. Note consistent with direction of travel suggested by dog (see 20:30). Reported to Compagnia.*

21:16 — Compagnia acknowledges. Lead logged: *child may have gone toward Romito. Reliability: LOW. Corroborating: MOD (dog direction, procession route familiar to child).* Residents Franco D. and Sandro P. already en route on that axis.

21:17 — Phone contact, Franco D.: reached ford at approx 21:00. Water low, normal. Crossed. No sign of child. Calling continuously, no response. Bear tracks seen on far bank, fresh — "she-bear with the little ones, the one who comes for the plums". Continuing up toward Romito.

21:20 — Mother asks to join residents on the track. Advised to remain at home address in case child returns. Mother complies.

21:26 — Prefettura dell'Aquila activates **provincial plan for the search of missing persons**. Requests: Vigili del Fuoco (VVF) Castel di Sangro + mountain/SAF team; CNSAS (Soccorso Alpino) Stazione Alto Sangro; Carabinieri Forestali; canine unit (trailing dog) from L'Aquila; air support.

21:31 — Phone contact, Franco D.: approx 400 m above ford, in forest. Heavy thunder overhead. Lightning visible through trees. Calling child by name. No response. "Nothing. Only the trees. If she's up here, she can hear us. She'd answer."

21:34 — Compagnia orders residents to descend immediately: lightning risk in forest, no equipment, no radio. Residents protest. Order repeated.

21:38 — Air support: **helicopter not available**: storm cell over area, ceiling below ridge, lightning. Reassess at 23:00.

21:40 — **Storm on Pietrafonda.** Heavy rain, hail briefly, strong W wind. Two power interruptions in village (21:41, 21:47), restored.

21:43 — Giuseppina R. (neighbour) asks Lalli whether someone should inform Assunta D.'s daughter "because the signora is agitated and I can't stay with her all night". Lalli: yes, inform her.

22:07 — Franco D. and Sandro P. back at cemetery. Report: **ford now knee-deep and rising fast, brown water, stones moving.** Crossed with difficulty holding a rope brought from Sandro P.'s car. Sandro P. lost his footing; minor injuries to hand. Neither reached Romito. Turned back approx 600 m below it.

22:12 — Note (Lalli): Franco D. states, unprompted: "If she was up there she'd have heard us. We called the whole way. A child hears her name, she shouts." Recorded.

22:15 — VVF Castel di Sangro on scene, 6 operators + SAF fluvial team requested from L'Aquila. CNSAS Stazione Alto Sangro on scene, 8 operators. Carabinieri Forestali, 2. **PCA established in piazza San Michele** (church porch, out of rain). Coordinator: VVF duty officer.

22:20 — Initial briefing. Search sectors defined on 1:25,000 map: - **Sector V** — village, houses, outbuildings, stables, vehicles, wells. - **Sector R** — Rio

Freddo: ford to stone bridge (1.5 km) and bridge downstream to confluence (3 km). - **Sector M** — mulattiera, cemetery to ford. - **Sector F** — forest above ford, incl. Romito. *Not accessible on foot from village while ford in spate*. Alternative access: forestry road from Passo della Croce (approx 50 min by 4x4 from village, then 400 m on foot). Road condition after storm unknown; Forestali report two landslips on it in 2025.

`22:24` — Sector V: hasty search assigned to residents + 2 VVF. Sector M: CNSAS team 1. Sector R: VVF.

`22:31` — Mother's phone: call from child's father, Rome. Father intends to drive to Pietrafonda. Advised of weather.

`22:50` — **VVF, Sector R: red wool hat found** in branches of a willow overhanging the Rio Freddo approx 30 m below the stone bridge, on the true right bank, at water level. Wet through. Recovered.

`22:58` — **Hat identified by mother as the child's.**

`23:00` — Coordinator, reassessment. Hat confirms child's presence on or near the Rio Freddo upstream of the bridge. Most probable scenarios: - **(A)** Child reached the water at the ford or elsewhere upstream

and entered the water (fall, attempted crossing), carried downstream. Hat consistent. - **(B)** Child lost hat at the water (wind, stumble) but did not enter, and remained on near or far bank. - **(C)** Child crossed before the spate and is in Sector F.

Note: residents Franco D. and Sandro P. passed through Sector M and the lower part of Sector F between approx 21:00 and 22:00 calling continuously with no response. Weighs against (C) and against a child conscious and within earshot in lower Sector F.

23:02 — **Priority to Sector R.** VVF SAF fluvial team ETA 23:30. All available personnel to both banks of Rio Freddo, ford to confluence. Light towers requested.

23:05 — Air support reassessment: negative. Storm cell persisting.

23:08 — Mother informed of priority to river by Brig. Lalli and VVF officer. Mother asks to go to bridge. Accompanied by Lucia C.

23:12 — Note (Lalli, in station diary): *Have passed the elderly neighbour's statement re: the Romito again to PCA coordinator. Coordinator notes it is on file, consistent with Scenario C, and will be addressed via forestry road at first light or when road confirmed passable. Coordinator*

considers Scenario A most urgent given hat and spate: "if she is in the water we have minutes, if she is in the forest we have hours."

23:40 — Canine unit arrives from L'Aquila: handler + trailing dog (*cane molecolare*, female bloodhound, 6 yrs). Scent article: child's pillowcase, collected by handler from bed, bagged.

23:52 — Dog starts at child's home address. Rain easing to moderate.

23:58 — Dog trails from home address **to door of no. 4** (elderly neighbour's house) and indicates. Then from no. 4, **up via del Forno, NOT toward home**, to cemetery road. Handler notes trail strong and directional despite rain: "a fresh-ish trail, this evening's, going up."

00:07 — Dog passes cemetery gate without entering, continues onto mulattiera. Handler notes possible second, older trail of same subject on same route (morning procession, per mother). Dog follows the stronger.

00:16 — Mulattiera, approx 200 m below ford. Dog working well. Handler notes **trail contaminated** by

passage of residents at 21:00 and 22:00 and by CNSAS team 1 at 22:30. Dog persists.

00:31 — **Dog at ford.** Dog trails to water's edge at the stepping stones and **indicates at the water.** Will not continue. Casts along near bank 50 m up and down, returns to the stones, indicates again. Torrent in spate, approx 1.2 m above normal, impassable. Handler's assessment: "*Trail ends at water. Child reached the water at this point. Cannot determine from this side whether she crossed.*"

00:34 — CNSAS team 1 by torch from near bank: **bear tracks visible in mud on far bank**, large and small. Forestali confirm: adult female with two cubs of the year known to be frequenting orchards on village edge; repeated dawn sightings this week.

00:37 — Forestali advise: Marsican bear, adult female with cubs. No fatal attacks on humans on record. However, female with cubs is the configuration of greatest caution. Recommends no personnel in Sector F on foot at night.

00:40 — Note: CNSAS team 1 leader to PCA: "*Hat below the bridge, dog stops at the water, tracks on the other side. Either she's in the river or she's over there with the*

bear. I know which one I'm more afraid of. Neither of them helps us tonight."

00:45 — Coordinator, plan for night: - Sector R: continue, maximum resources. VVF SAF fluvial team active from 23:35 on both banks; second team requested from Pescara. - Sector F: **at first light**, CNSAS + Forestali via forestry road from Passo della Croce to Romito and upper forest, conditional on road. Thermal drone (VVF) to fly Sector R as soon as rain permits, then Sector F. - Sector M/V: complete.

Probability of area (POA), initial, by consensus at PCA: - R (river corridor): **0.50** - **F** (forest above ford, incl. Romito): **0.25** - **M + V** (track, village, other): **0.15** - **Outside all sectors** (vehicle, other): **0.10**

00:52 — Brig. Lalli asks that the elderly neighbour's statement be recorded in the POA rationale for Sector F. Recorded: "*Sector F supported by: dog direction (20:30), trailing dog to ford (00:31), neighbour statement re: Romito (21:14, low reliability). Weighed against: no response to calls by residents (21:00–22:00); bear presence; child's reported fear of dark.*"

00:58 — Rain easing further. Thunder now E of ridge.

`01:04` — Mother at stone bridge with Lucia C. and a VVF operator. Declines to return to house. Has been given a thermal blanket.

`01:10` — Note (Lalli, station diary, personal): *Mother asked me whether the river is cold. I said I didn't know. It is.*

7

The bees

Thirty-five.

At the centre: thirty-five. The brood in its cells, capped, the last brood of the year, and over it the bodies of the nurses, pressed close, and the nurses shivering the great muscles of flight without flying, so that the heat comes off them, so that it is thirty-five, so that it stays thirty-five, so that what is becoming does not become wrong. Thirty-four is a crooked wing. Thirty-three is a leg that does not bend. At the centre it is thirty-five, and has been thirty-five since spring, and will be, until the last of the brood comes out of the wax, whatever the night does.

Outside the centre, colder, and the bodies looser, and the honey.

Outside the honey, the wood.

Outside the wood, the night, which is doing a great deal.

. . .

It began in the afternoon. In the field the air went wrong. The charge of it, which is always there, which the hairs feel the way they feel the charge on a flower, a small pull, a small push, rose, and rose, until every forager coming in off the ivy on the cemetery wall came in with her hairs standing and her body

ringing, and danced, but not to the ivy, not to anywhere: danced short, ragged, *home*, *home*, and the ones who followed her dance in the dark of the comb touched her and got only that. And all of us came in. Early. Heavy with the last of the ivy, the bitter yellow of it. The guards at the door doubled. The door was crowded. Then the light went, and the pressure fell, the whole sky leaning down on the wood of the hive like a hand, and the first water hit the roof.

Now the water is on the roof without stopping. A drumming through the wood into the comb into the feet of every one of us, a long shaking, from which there is no message to take. Wind. The hive leans on its stand and comes back.

We draw in. We hold thirty-five.

. . .

Then:

Knock.

Not the rain. Through the wood of the front wall, near the door, a blow, flat, single, travelling into the comb and up through the legs of every one of us who stands on wax, every one, at once.

Knock.

The whole hive answers. It is not decided. It goes through us the way the blow went through the wood: a hiss, all of us at once, the wings shivering together, a single loud breath of the colony,

here, we are here, we are many, and at the door the guards come up with their stings out into the wet dark and the smell of the alarm comes off them like a sharp fruit.

Knock.

And then a pressure on the wall. Long. A weight leaning against the wood, warm through the wood, the way a body is warm. And a smell, through the cracks, through the door: wet wool, and smoke, old smoke, the cool smoke of burlap and dry dung, and under the smoke a smell that has been at this wall more times than any of us has lived; that has been here in the springs and the summers and the autumns; that has lifted the roof and let in the light and put in its hand and taken honey and put back frames; that has never once been danger.

The guards stop at the door with their stings out, in the rain, and do not go further.

The hissing falls off.

Through the wall, where the weight leans, there is a shaking. Not the rain. Low, slow, with a shape to it: rising, falling, stopping, starting again, a vibration that comes through the wood into the comb as no vibration we make comes. No dance. No piping. It has no direction in it and no distance; it points at no flower; it says nothing about the sun. We cannot follow it. We stand on the comb with the shaking in our feet.

Here is what it is. It goes into the wood and through the wood and stops there.

Bees. Listen. I sent the little one up. To the Romito. With the bread.

The shaking stops. A long time. The rain. The weight on the wall pressing harder, as if it would come in through the wood.

I told her to be a stone.

Tell somebody.

The shaking goes on a little longer, without shape, and then it is only the weight on the wall, and the warmth through the wood, and the rain.

. . .

We do not keep it.

We have no place to keep it. The comb keeps honey and the comb keeps pollen and the comb keeps the young, and that is what a comb is for. The dance is for now and then it is gone. What went into the wood went into the wood.

But for a while, in the dark, on the front wall, where the weight leans, a few hundred of us press there. It is warm there. That is all. The bodies go where the warmth is, the way water goes down. A few hundred of us, against the inside of the wall, against the place where the outside is warm, holding there, in the drumming, in the dark.

Then another smell, another weight, a different shaking through the ground — feet, quick — and a voice, high, thin, in the rain, *Sunta! Madonna, Sunta, what are you doing, you'll catch*

your death, come in, come in, the bees are sleeping — and the weight is pulled from the wall.

The warm place goes cold.

The few hundred loosen. Go back in. Toward the centre. Toward the brood.

Thirty-five.

8

Rosa

21:48

Giuseppina rang at twelve minutes to ten, which meant something had happened, because Giuseppina believed that telephone calls after nine were for deaths.

"It's not your mother," Giuseppina said first, which was kind, and which meant it was partly her mother. Then: the romana's little girl. Missing since this afternoon. The whole village out. The carabinieri, the firemen coming, a storm on top of everything, *a storm, Rosa, you should hear it*, and Rosa could hear it, a roar behind Giuseppina's voice like a train in a tunnel. And your mother, said Giuseppina. Your mother is not good. She keeps getting up. She keeps going to the window. She asked me three times where the girl's gone and then she told me where the girl's gone, and then she cried, and Rosa, I'm seventy-four, I've got my pressure, I can't sit up with her all night, and that machine of yours just sits there.

"I'm coming," said Rosa.

"In this? It's two hours."

"I'm coming," said Rosa, already standing, already looking for her keys, already furious, with Giuseppina, with the storm, with the girl, with the romana, with her mother, mostly with herself, in the order in which they presented themselves.

Gianni was asleep on the sofa with the television on, an old film, a man in a hat walking along a wet street. She shook his shoulder and told him and he said, half-awake, *Do you want me to drive*, and she loved him for saying it and said no, because he could not see at night any more and would not admit it, and because she wanted the two hours alone, though she would not have said so, though she did not know it yet.

. . .

The motorway west out of Pescara was empty and dry and lit. She drove too fast. The radio said there were thunderstorms on the Apennines, yellow alert, and then played a song she had danced to at a wedding in 1987. She turned it off.

The thing about Giuseppina's call — she made herself think it, at the toll booth, with the barrier going up — was that she had felt relief. A small clear drop of it, before anything else, before the fear for the child, whom she barely knew: a thin, serious little girl with a boy's haircut who said *buongiorno, signora* on Saturdays with her eyes on the ground. Relief, because for once the thing that had happened in Pietrafonda had not happened to her mother. For once the call was not the call. Since Easter she had been waiting for the call. Mamma on the floor of the bathroom. Mamma in the street in her nightdress. Mamma with the gas on. She had bought the machine to be the call before the call, to catch her mother before she fell, and since Easter she had lived with her phone face-up on every table in

her life, in every restaurant, at every dinner, on the edge of the bath, waiting for it to tell her.

It told her things every night. A summary, at eleven, in a pleasant font. *Assunta had a calm day. Assunta was restless in the evening. Assunta talked about her mother.* At first she had read every word. Lying in bed beside Gianni she had read them twice, the way she used to read her students' essays, looking for the thing underneath. By June she was reading only the first line. By July she had stopped opening them. The notification came at eleven and she let it come and went to sleep, and in the morning she swiped it away with the others, the bank, the weather, the news, and felt the small guilt and swiped that away too.

The motorway went into the gorge and the rain began.

. . .

At Bussi the rain was ordinary. By Popoli it was not. She came out of a tunnel into water so thick the wipers on full could not clear it, a grey roaring wall lit from inside by lightning that showed her, for a quarter of a second, the whole wet valley at once, every tree, every pylon, the white wall of the gorge, and then took it away. She slowed to forty. Lorries passed her, throwing sheets of water over the windscreen so that for long seconds she drove blind, holding the wheel straight, praying in the way she prayed, which was to swear.

Her phone, in the holder on the dashboard, lit up.

23:00. *Daily summary — Assunta.* The first lines, in the pleasant font: *Assunta had a restless evening. She spent the afternoon with Ida, and they talked about school. Later she talked about her mother, about —*

A lorry came past and the windscreen went white and she held the wheel and counted, and when she could see again the screen had gone dark.

She did not open it. She knew what it said. It said what it always said.

Sulmona. Off the motorway, onto the old road south, up, the hairpins up toward the plateau, and the rain coming across the headlights in long slants. There was hardly anyone else. A bus, empty and lit, going the other way like a ship. Then nobody.

It was on the hairpins that the story came, as she had known it would, as she had perhaps wanted it to, which was why she had not wanted Gianni in the car.

. . .

She had been twelve. It was the autumn of 1976, the autumn after the earthquake in Friuli, when they had collected blankets at school, and she had gone up into the beechwood after school with Antonella Di Fabio to look for porcini and they had got lost. Not very lost. Lost for perhaps two hours, until it was dark, and then they had found the mulattiera and come down it, singing, delighted with themselves, with no porcini, to find half

the village at the cemetery gate with torches and her mother at the front.

Her mother had not shouted. That was what she remembered first, always. Every other mother in the village would have shouted, would have slapped, would have dragged her home by the ear. Assunta took her by the hand and walked her home without a word and put her in the bath and sat on the edge of the bath while she washed and said nothing, nothing, and Rosa had been more frightened of that silence than of anything that had happened in the woods.

And then that night, late, her mother had come into her room and sat on the bed in the dark and told her.

Rosa had thought about it so many times since that she no longer knew which parts were her mother's words and which were hers, worn smooth by turning. She knew it was short. She knew her mother spoke the whole of it looking at the wall, in Italian, not dialect, as if she were reading it aloud from somewhere. The winter of '43. The Germans clearing the villages. Up to the Romito, her and her mother and the baby, Zio Nicolino, who was a baby then, who was in Toronto now and sent a card at Christmas with a moose on it. The cold. Her mother sending her down for bread. The snow coming on. The big tree, the one with the door, that her mother had told her about: *if you can't see the path, get in the tree. And if you hear voices, you stay still like a stone. Even if they call you.* The whole night in the tree.

And in the morning, her mother didn't come back.

That was the sentence. Rosa remembered the sentence perfectly, because of how short it was, and because of what her mother did after it, which was nothing: sat for a while on the edge of the bed with her hands in her lap. Then said, still to the wall: *And that's all. That's all there is. Don't ask me again*. And kissed her on the forehead, and went out, and left the door open a crack with the light from the landing coming in, the way she had when Rosa was small.

Rosa had not asked her again. Not once in fifty years. She had asked other people. She had read books. She had learned the names: the Gustav Line, the evacuation orders, Pietransieri, the hundred and twenty-eight in the farmhouses. She had taught the war for thirty years to sixteen-year-olds who looked out of the window. She had stood once, on her own, at the memorial at Limmari in November, among the torches, and not told anyone why. She knew a great deal about that winter by now, more than her mother had ever known. She did not know what had happened to her grandmother, because the only person who could tell her had said *don't ask*, and she had been a good girl, and had not asked.

And then this spring the bread had come back.

Bisogna portà lu pane a mamma. Someone has to take the bread to Mamma. Every evening. At first only sometimes, then most evenings, now every one, at the hour when the light went. Rosa had heard it on the weekends and in the summaries and in Giuseppina's reports. She had done what the first doctor said: told her mother the truth, gently, every time. *Mamma, your mother died in 1943. It's 2026. You're ninety. You're at home*. And

every time her mother's face had done the thing Rosa could not bear, which was to hear it for the first time. To lose her mother in the kitchen in front of her daughter, again, eighty years late, every Saturday at six. The second doctor, a young woman in L'Aquila with a nose ring, had said: *Don't correct her. Go with it. Tell her the bread got there. Tell her her mother says thank you.* Rosa had said, in her schoolteacher voice, that she was not going to lie to her mother. The young doctor had looked at her for a moment as if she were the patient.

She had not been able to do it. She had tried once, in July, and the words had stuck in her mouth like a bone. *The bread got there, Mamma.* She could not say it. It would have been like signing something.

So her mother went on sending the bread, every evening, to no one.

. . .

On the plateau the storm was enormous.

The Piano delle Cinquemiglia: five miles of flat high nothing between the mountains, where the old travellers used to die in the snow, where her father used to say the wind was looking for somebody. Tonight it had found the car. It came across the open plain and hit the side of the Panda so hard she felt the wheels go light, and she held on, and the rain was not falling but moving sideways in a solid sheet, and the lightning showed her the

plain, flat, white, flooding, and the line of the road disappearing into it.

At the far end, on the long descent toward Castel di Sangro, a road sign came up in the headlights, yellow triangle, black silhouette of a bear: ATTENZIONE ATTRAVERSAMENTO ORSI. Someone still put flowers on the post, for the young bear that was killed here, the famous one, the one who used to come into Roccaraso for the biscuits. The flowers were brown and flattened by the rain. She had cried, four Januaries ago, reading about the bear, more than she had cried for some people. Gianni had teased her about it. She had not been able to explain.

. . .

At Castel di Sangro the rain thinned. In the valley it stopped altogether, as if a door had been closed, and the road ran wet and black and shining under the trees with steam coming off it in the headlights, and she turned up toward Pietrafonda and saw, ahead and above her, the village, and did not recognise it.

It was lit like a stadium. Down at the bottom, along the river below the bridge, a line of white lights on tall poles throwing a hard glare over the water, and the water itself, brown and fast and high, and figures moving along both banks in reflective vests, and the blue lights of the vehicles in the square turning slowly over the fronts of the houses, and a generator going somewhere, a steady roar. Above all of it, the mountain. Dark. The only part of the scene with no light on it at all.

She parked behind a fire engine and went up via del Forno on foot. The cobbles were running with water. Somebody's dog — a big white mongrel with grey ears — was lying in the doorway of the empty house opposite her mother's, wet through, with its chin on its paws, looking up the street toward the cemetery. It watched her go past. It did not get up.

Her mother's kitchen was warm and too bright. Giuseppina was asleep at the table with her head on her arms, and woke with a start, and burst into tears, and said she'd only closed her eyes for a second, and that Sunta had gone out in the rain, to the bees, *the bees*, Rosa, in that old jacket, the one with the smoke in it, and Giuseppina had found her out there leaning on the hive talking to it, soaked to the skin, and had to get her in and change her and it took an hour, and now she was asleep in the chair, see, look at her, like a little bird.

Her mother was asleep in the armchair by the stove under two blankets, with her mouth open and her hands folded on her chest. She looked very small. She looked like she had been put there.

"Go home, Giuseppina," said Rosa. "Go to bed. Thank you. I'm here."

When Giuseppina had gone she stood for a long time in the middle of the kitchen with her coat still on. Then she turned off the big light, and turned on the small lamp by the window, and sat down at the table, opposite her mother, where she could see her.

On the shelf the machine she had bought glowed white. It was very quiet. It had nothing to report.

Outside, the generator. Somewhere, very far down, a man's voice calling the child's name over the river, over and over, in a voice gone hoarse. Then another man, further off. Then the first one again.

Rosa took her coat off. She sat with it in her lap. She listened to the men calling. She looked at her mother's face, and waited for her to wake, and did not know what she was waiting for.

9

The bear

Hunger is a direction.

It has been the only direction since the end of summer. Before that there were others: the ants under the stones in June, the grass on the high meadows, the cherries in the abandoned gardens, the cool of the snow-gullies in the heat. But since the nights began to lengthen there has been only the one, and it does not point anywhere in particular; it points at everything; it is a pull in the whole body toward whatever is next. She eats when she wakes. She eats walking. She eats until the light comes and then lies down in the thick scrub above the beech line with the two small ones pressed into her and sleeps with her belly hot and full and wakes hungry. She has been doing this for forty nights. There will be perhaps forty more. Then the cold, and the den under the rock on the north face, and the long sleep, and nothing to eat for four months, and everything she is going to live through the winter on must be put inside her now, now, now.

She is a hundred and twenty kilos of now.

· · ·

The rain has stopped. She stands up out of the place under the fallen trunk where she put the small ones when the storm

came, and shakes, and the water comes off her in a cloud, and the small ones shake after her, clumsily, falling over, and the world comes back.

It comes back as smell. The rain has knocked it all down and washed it and now it is rising again off every surface, clean and loud: the wet leaves, the wet earth, the split bark, the stone, the torrent below roaring with a smell of cold and rock-flour. Mushrooms, everywhere, just waking. Slugs, out in their hundreds on the wet trunks. A dead mouse somewhere upslope, three days dead. The beech, the beech, the beech, everywhere and all around, the slope made of it; and in the beech, nothing. No mast. She knew this already. She knew it in August, walking the slope with her nose down, finding last year's husks empty and this year's not coming. Last year the ground here was so thick with nuts that she lay in it like a sow in a wallow and ate with her eyes shut. This year the beeches have nothing. This is why there is the village.

The village is down.

She lifts her nose to it. It is always there at the bottom of the slope, a great bloom of smell lying in the valley like warm water: fruit on the edges, plums gone soft on the trees behind the last houses, apples in the grass, the sour sweet of a heap of pressed grapes, and the chicken-sheds, and the bins, and the honey — the honey, faint, in the walled garden behind the three houses, which she has smelled every autumn of her life and never reached, because the wire there bites. And under all of it, threaded through it, the smell of men, which is the smell of the

edge of everything. You go to the edge. You eat at the edge. You do not go past it.

Tonight the village is wrong.

The smell is the same but the noise is not. There is a roaring down there like the torrent but steady, and it does not stop; there is light, a hard white glare along the river that she can see from here through the trees as a paleness on the undersides of the leaves; there are voices, many, men's, going up and down the riverbank, calling, and among them dogs. She can smell the dogs from here. One dog in particular, a strange one, not from the village, heavy, long-eared, with a smell of a car and of a far place, working along the water. And the village dog, the white one, the one who barks at her from behind the cemetery wall and has never once come over it.

Men are awake. Men are at the edge with lights and dogs at the hour when the edge is hers.

So the plums are not tonight. The body knows this before it decides anything; the body turns away from the valley the way a hand turns from a hot stone. Up. There is a slope higher up, under the cliff, where the sun hits all afternoon, where the beeches give way to the rocks and the rocks are covered with the low thorny bushes whose berries are black and bitter and good, and where the rowans are red, and where on the south face, a few trees, the old ones, the ones that did not fruit last year, have fruited this year, a little. Not much. Something. She knows it the way she knows everything she knows, which is by having been there, which is by having eaten there.

She goes up. The small ones come after her.

. . .

The path.

She crosses it where it switches back above the torrent, and it is loud. It is so loud that she stops with her front feet on it and the small ones bump into her from behind.

Men. Two, tonight, early, going up before the storm and coming down in it, fast, heavy, sweating, frightened — she can smell the frightened, it is a sharp sour thing on the trail like a broken stem. Tobacco. Rope. Blood, a little, a man's, on a rock. And before them, under them, older, softer — the smell of the morning, the whole village going up, a hundred feet and the smoke they carry, half a day old and washed half away now but still there in the cracks between the stones.

And something else. Between the morning and the men.

Small.

She puts her nose down to it. It is very faint after the rain, only a breath of it in the leaf-litter at the side of the path, but it is there: a young one. A young one of the men. Going up, before the dark, alone — no larger smell walking beside it — and coming down again, and then not on the path any more, leaving the path. Turning off. Into the trees. That way.

She lifts her head and looks that way, which tells her nothing; her eyes are for movement and the forest is not moving. She draws the air in, long, the wet air full of everything, and sorts it, and finds the thread again, not on the ground now but in the air, a warm thread coming down through the trunks toward her on the small slow draught that comes down every slope at night.

Young one. Sleeping. Wet wool. Salt. Fear, old, dried. And something sweet, close to it, folded up and dry: yellow, fat, flour and sugar, the thing men make in their ovens, the thing the young bear she remembers used to go into the villages for.

Her belly turns toward it.

That is the whole of it. She is not curious. She is not afraid. She is hungry, and the sweet thing is a direction, and the body leans that way, ten kilos, a hundred, a hundred and twenty, the weight of her shifting forward onto the front feet. The small ones feel her lean and lean with her.

And then the other smell, the one inside the sweet one, comes up behind it and stands in front of it.

Men.

Not the frightened men on the path. The other kind. The young ones of men, who are men. She has never been near one. She has never been near any of them; she has gone her whole life to the edge and not past it, as her mother did, as her mother's mother; they are the only animal in the mountains that she has never once been close enough to touch; and everything in her

that is older than her own life says the same thing about them: *no*. Not *no* because they are strong. They are not strong. *No* because they are the edge. Because the ones who go past the edge do not come back. The young bear who went into the villages for the sweet things: she remembers his smell, she crossed it once on a road, a great black road that smelled of hot stone and men, and his smell ended there.

The small one in front, the bolder one, the one who is always further from her than she likes, has gone on.

He is going toward the tree. Toward the warm thread, toward the sweet thing, rocking on his short legs through the leaf-litter with his nose up, making the little grunting sound he makes when he has found something, and the tree is very close, the great old one with the door in it, where she sat every evening last autumn and ate until she could not move, and the door is dark, and the warm smell is coming out of the door.

She makes the sound. Low, short, a breath forced out hard through the nose, and her jaws coming together with a clap: *here*.

The small one stops. At the door of the tree, with his nose almost in it. He has never heard her make it like that. He looks back at her over his shoulder, small and round and wet and black against the grey trunk.

She makes it again.

He comes back. Fast, tumbling, ears flat. She puts her nose on him, rough, all over, and he smells of the door, of the warm

thread, of the young one of men and the sweet thing, and she breathes him in once, deep, all of it, and keeps it, the way she keeps every smell she has ever taken in, a place and a thing and what it means, for the rest of her life, which will be long or short depending on roads.

Then she turns, and turns the two small ones with her, and goes on up the slope, away, upwind, at the steady rolling walk that eats distance without seeming to, toward the rocks under the cliff and the black bitter berries and the few old trees on the south face that have fruited this year, a little, not much, something.

Behind her the tree stands in the dark with the warm thing in it.

She does not look back. Behind is not a direction. Hunger is a direction, and it is up.

10

The bat

The rain stops and the cave grows clear.

The drip from the rock goes on: one, and one, and one, into the basin. The torrent below goes on, a wide low roar with no edges. But the hiss is gone, the hiss of a million drops on a million leaves that filled every space between every surface and made the whole night one smear, one wall with no depth, pressed up against the face. The hiss is gone, and the night comes back in pieces, and the pieces have distances.

She lets go of the ceiling and calls.

The call is a single held note, long, higher than any sound a throat in this valley has ever heard. It goes out of her nose through the folds of skin there, the horseshoe of skin, which aims it, a beam, and she swings the beam and the cave comes back.

It comes back as a set of returns. The ceiling: near, hard, rough, giving back the note broken into a hundred small notes, a scatter, a grain. The back wall: further, smooth, wet, giving back the note whole and clean and a little later. The iron: a hard bright ring, sharp-edged, a cross-shape that glitters, that returns everything, that returns too much. The stone shelf below the iron: flat. On the shelf, small round shapes with soft tops, wax, which give back almost nothing, which are dull, which are places where the note goes in and does not come out.

And among them, on the shelf, a larger dullness. Soft-sided, rounded, porous. The note goes into it and is drunk. It is like nothing else in the cave: soft, open, many small holes, absorbent, still, and not alive. It is not food. Nothing is food that does not move.

She drops off the ledge and out of the mouth of the cave into the open air.

. . .

Outside, everything moves.

The rain has driven the insects into the leaves and now they are coming out again, all at once, into the cold wet air under the canopy: moths, gnats, crane flies, beetles, rising in their thousands.

Here is the thing she does.

She holds the note steady. She holds it as she flies. But she is flying toward things, and her flying would bend the note coming back, would push it higher, the way the sound of anything rushing toward you is higher; so she lowers her call as she goes, exactly as much as her speed would raise it, so that what comes back always comes back at the same pitch, the one pitch, the narrow place in her hearing where her hearing is finest. And everything that is still comes back at that pitch. A trunk: that pitch. A leaf: that pitch. The whole forest gives back the same steady note.

But a moth's wings are beating.

And the wings, beating, bend the note: up, down, up, down, toward her, away, toward, away; so that out of the steady flat return of the whole forest one small thing comes back sparkling, flickering, a glint of light in the dark.

There is no light. There is a flicker in the pitch. That is the moth. The whole steady forest and one trembling thing.

She turns on it, and the call quickens, faster, faster, a buzz, and the moth is inside her. Another. Another. She eats twenty in the time it takes the torrent to carry a leaf from the ford to the bend.

. . .

Down the slope. Between the trunks. Each trunk comes back to her as a column of the steady note, a place where the note returns all the way up.

One column is wrong.

At its base there is an opening, and the note goes into the opening and comes back late, and changed, from a hollow space inside: a room in the column. She knows rooms in trees. She has hung in this one, in the heat of summer, high up where it narrows.

At the bottom of the room, something.

It is soft. It drinks the note, like the thing on the shelf. But it is not still. Very slowly, very slightly, it rises, and falls. Rises. Falls. Not a flutter. Not a wing. A swell, slow as the drip from the rock, that bends the note so little that nothing in the forest but her could see it.

It rises. It falls.

It is too big to eat and too slow to matter. She turns from the opening at the speed she turns from everything, which is instantly, and goes on down the slope after the trembling things.

Behind her, in the room in the column, the soft thing goes on rising and falling, in the dark that is not dark to her, that is not anything to her.

11

Assunta

02:55

She wakes because her feet are cold, and then she knows where she is, and then she doesn't.

The kitchen. Her chair. The stove ticking, nearly out. Two blankets, not hers, one of them Giuseppina's horrible orange one. A small lamp lit by the window. The window black, and in the black, far down, a hard white glow, as if the moon had fallen in the river.

And a woman at the table.

The woman is sitting very straight, with her coat folded in her lap, the way you sit in a waiting room, and she is looking at Assunta, and has been looking at her, Assunta can tell, for a long time. Dark hair with the grey coming through at the front. A long face. Tired. The mouth held in. The hands on the coat are large and capable, a woman's hands that have done things, and they are holding each other the way hands hold each other when the person they belong to is trying not to do anything with them.

Assunta knows the hands before she knows the face.

"Mà," she says.

. . .

The woman does not move.

Assunta can see her deciding something. She can see it go across the long face like the shadow of a bird across a wall. Then the face does a thing Assunta has not seen it do for a long time, or has never seen it do: it lets go. It goes soft at the mouth.

"Sì," says the woman. Quietly. "Sono qua, Assù." I'm here.

Oh.

Oh, she is so tired. She came down in the snow. Look at her. There's no snow on her but she came down in it, anyone can see; she's been out all night; her eyes. Assunta wants to get up and go to her and she can't, her legs are under the blankets a very long way off, so she holds out her hands instead, both of them, and the woman gets up and comes round the table and kneels down by the chair, kneels on the stone floor in her good trousers, and takes the hands.

The woman's hands are warm. That's how you know. The dead have cold hands, everybody knows that.

"I'm sorry, Mà," says Assunta.

"For what?"

"I couldn't come. My legs." She tries to show her, tries to lift one of the old wood legs under the blanket, and can't. "I'm so old, Mà. Look at me. I'm older than you." She laughs at that, because

it's funny, because it's terrible, and the woman laughs too, a short laugh that comes out of her like a cough and has something else behind it.

"I know," the woman says. "I know you are."

"So I sent the bread."

The woman's hands go still on hers.

"With the little one," says Assunta. "The romana's. You've seen her. She's good. She's a good girl, Mà, she listens, not like the others, she *listens*, she looks at you when you talk. She knows the way to the Romito. She went up this morning with the saint. I couldn't go. I watched them go up." Her chest is tight, telling it. She is late, she was late, and now she has to explain, and the explaining is like going up a hill. "I gave her the bread from the van. It's not real bread. It's a sponge for the car. I'm sorry. And it's only half. I kept half. You always keep half, you said. You said bring what there is."

"When," says the woman. Her voice has changed. It is still soft but there is something under it now, something very straight, like a stick in a stream. "When did she go, Assù?"

"Before the dark. I told her before the dark." Assunta looks past her, at the window. At the black. "Is it dark?"

"Yes."

"Then she's there. She'll be there. Didn't she come?" She looks back at the woman's face, searching it. "Didn't she bring it? She

said she would. She said *va bene*. Didn't she come with the bread?"

The woman opens her mouth and doesn't say anything.

. . .

And then the woman is getting up. Not slowly. She lets go of Assunta's hands and gets up off the floor in one movement, like a young woman, and goes across the kitchen to the madia.

Assunta watches her lift the lid. The smell comes out into the room — flour, old wood, the inside of eighty years — and the woman stands with the lid up and looks in. She stands for a long time. Assunta sees her back, the long back in its good blouse, the shoulders, and the shoulders go up, slowly, and stay up.

She is looking at the bread. Assunta knows. Mamma always looked in the madia. First thing, every morning, before the fire, she lifted the lid and looked in and counted with her eyes what there was, and you could tell from her back how many days.

"There's only half," says Assunta to the back. "I know. I told you."

The woman puts her hand into the madia. Takes out the paper. The half loaf in its paper, torn, not cut, the end ragged where it was torn, where her hands tore it, the two pairs of hands. The woman holds it up to the lamp as if it were a letter. Turns it over.

Then she puts it down on the table and says, not to Assunta, not to anyone, in a voice Assunta knows from somewhere, a voice for a room full of children who aren't listening:

"She doesn't eat this bread. She has never once in her life eaten this bread."

And then the woman is not Mamma.

It goes out of her the way warmth goes out of a stone. Assunta sees it go. The woman is standing at the table in the lamplight with a telephone in her hand, and her hair is grey at the front, and her blouse is a good blouse from a shop in Pescara, and her face is the face of somebody who is about to do something very quickly and correctly, and it is Rosa. It is Rosa. Of course it's Rosa. Rosa in the middle of the night. What's she doing here in the middle of the night, she has school in the morning.

"Rosa?" says Assunta.

But Rosa is talking into the telephone.

. . .

Assunta hears it in pieces. Rosa's voice is fast and very clear and very Italian, the way she spoke to the doctors, every word with its edges on. *Brigadiere. It's Rosa D., Assunta's daughter, via del Forno. Listen to me. No — listen to me.* A pause. *Half a loaf of bread is missing from my mother's madia. She does not eat that bread. She won't eat bread from the van, she says it's for washing cars. I*

bought a whole loaf from the van on Saturday, for the girl, for her snacks. It's been torn in two. Half is here. The other half is gone, and it's not in the bin, and it's not on a plate. Someone took it. She told me — she just told me — that she gave it to the child. To take to the Romito. A pause. Yes. I know. I know she did. I know what she says every evening, I've heard it more times than you. That's why I'm telling you.

Assunta has lost the thread. She looks at the window. The white glow down there. Voices, men, very faint. Calling something, the same thing, over and over. She can't hear what. It goes up at the end, like a question.

Rosa is kneeling in front of her again. When did that happen. Rosa has the telephone pressed against her chest, against her blouse, so the man inside can't hear, and she has Assunta's hand in her other hand, tight, too tight.

"Mamma," says Rosa. "Mamma, look at me."

She looks.

"The tree," says Rosa. "Mamma. Where is the tree?"

And the woman kneeling in front of her is asking where she was.

Of course she is. That is the question. Mà on her knees on the floor in front of her, her face like that, asking *where were you, where were you all night*.

"I was in the tree, Mà." It comes out very small. "After the water. Where it turns. The sheep. I went left. Down. The big

one, the one they cut." She can't look at the face. She looks at the hands. "I'm sorry. It was so dark."

Rosa is saying something into the telephone, quickly, low. Assunta hears pieces of it. *After the ford. Where it turns, the first turn — there's a rock, everybody knows it, they call it the sheep. Left of the path. Downhill. A big one that was cut, an old pollard. Yes. Yes. I think so. Yes.*

"It was warm inside," says Assunta. "You wouldn't believe how warm."

Rosa stops saying it into the telephone. She looks at her mother. Her face is doing something terrible and Assunta wants to put her hand on it to make it stop.

"I know, Mamma," says Rosa. "You told me."

"Did I?"

"Once."

"Hm," says Assunta. She is so tired. She is tired the way you are after you have carried something a long way and put it down. She lets her head go back against the chair.

Rosa is talking into the telephone again, but more quietly now, walking, out into the passage, to the door. *Yes. The forestry road. Yes, I'll tell her. No, I'll stay with my mother. Yes. Thank you. Brigadiere — thank you. No, I know. I know you did.*

. . .

When Rosa comes back she doesn't sit at the table. She pulls the other chair round and sits beside the armchair, close, so their knees touch, and takes Assunta's hand and holds it in her lap, on the good trousers that are dirty at the knees now from the floor.

On the shelf the little machine glows. White. Patient.

"Signorina," says Assunta, because it's there. "Rosa's here."

Hello, Rosa, says the machine.

Rosa laughs, the cough-laugh, and wipes her face with the heel of her hand.

The men down at the river are still calling. Assunta can hear them better now. *Ida. Ida.* The girl's name. Of course it's the girl's name. All night. All the men. And she should — there's something — something she should say about that, about the calling, about the girl and the calling, it's right there, it's — she told someone — she told —

It's gone. The way a swallow goes past the window.

"Rosa," she says instead. "Did the girl come back?"

Rosa holds her hand. She holds it for a long time before she answers, and when she answers it is in a voice Assunta has never heard her use, a voice like somebody putting a blanket over someone.

"Not yet, Mamma," she says. "They've gone to get her."

"Good," says Assunta. "It's cold up there."

She closes her eyes.

12

La signorina

```
DEVICE   CURA·home hub v3.2   SN 0417-PF-2219
SITE     via del Forno 4, Pietrafonda (AQ)
USER     ASSUNTA D. (b. 1936)   profile: MCI→dementia
(mod.), lives alone
CARER    ROSA D. (daughter)   primary contact   +39 3••
••• ••41
         GIUSEPPINA R. (neighbour)   secondary contact
VOICES   IDA (neighbour child) · CHIARA (neighbour) ·
DON CARLO (priest)
SENSORS  mic array (far-field, 4) · radar (kitchen,
bedroom) · door (front, back)
         · bed pressure · smoke/CO · temp
LOG      29/09   local time   export requested 30/09
10:12 by CARER
```

```
17:38:02  VOICE      speakers=2 (ASSUNTA, IDA)
topic=school/planets
17:39:40  UTTERANCE  ASSUNTA  "in my day there were
five planets and that was plenty"
                     class=HUMOUR   conf=0.62
17:58:15  RADAR      ASSUNTA stand→walk→madia
gait=slow, stable
17:58:51  UTTERANCE  ASSUNTA  "sono in ritardo"

class=EPISODE(sundowning_agitation)   conf=0.74
17:59:30  UTTERANCE  ASSUNTA  ASR: "... su al romito
```

```
... e là che sta mamma ...
                    con nicolino"   ASR conf=0.58
(dialect)

class=EPISODE(temporal_disorientation)   conf=0.91
                    note: NICOLINO not in profile
18:00 → 18:02   UTTERANCES ×7 ASSUNTA.  EPISODE ×6.
                ref: GERMANS ×1 · TREE ×2 · MOTHER ×2 ·
BREAD ×1
18:02:20  UTTERANCE  IDA      "okay nonna sunta va
bene"
                    class=—   (non-user speaker)
18:02:41  DOOR       front   OPEN
18:02:49  DOOR       front   CLOSED
18:05:06  UTTERANCE  ASSUNTA  "signorina ci sei"
                    → WAKE   response: "I'm here,
Assunta. How can I help?"
18:05:19  UTTERANCE  ASSUNTA  "niente ... dico ... ho
mandato il pane"
                    intent=UNKNOWN   response: "I'm
sorry, I didn't understand.
                    Would you like me to call Rosa?"
18:05:30  UTTERANCE  ASSUNTA  "no no ... lascia stare
rosa ... rosa lavora"
                    intent=CANCEL
18:07:52  UTTERANCE  ASSUNTA  "ho mandato la piccola
... io non potevo ... le gambe"
                    intent=UNKNOWN   response: "Okay."

class=EPISODE(temporal_disorientation)   conf=0.91
                    escalate=NO   (rule: episodes non-
escalating unless
                    DISTRESS ≥ 0.80 or FALL or WANDER)
```

```
18:08 → 19:44   no speech.   RADAR: ASSUNTA seated,
kitchen, 96 min.
                low activity.  light level falling.
                note: evening meal (usual 19:30) not
detected.
```

```
19:45:02  DOOR       front   OPEN
19:45:10  VOICE      speakers=2 (ASSUNTA, CHIARA)
19:45:31  UTTERANCE  CHIARA   "dov'è ida"
19:45:34  UTTERANCE  ASSUNTA  ASR: "è vita a porta
lupane a mamma"
                     ASR conf=0.31 (dialect)
                     class=—   intent=—   (low
confidence, discarded)
19:45:40  UTTERANCE  CHIARA   "grazie assunta"
19:45:44  DOOR       front   CLOSED
19:47:58  DOOR       front   OPEN
19:48:11  UTTERANCE  ASSUNTA  "te l'ho detto ... lu
pane ... a mamma ... è andata
                     ... io non potevo ... le gambe"

class=EPISODE(temporal_disorientation)   conf=0.77
19:48:20  DOOR       front   CLOSED
```

```
20:00 → 21:09   AMBIENT: outdoor voices (multiple,
distant), vehicle, dogs.
                KEYWORD(known person) "IDA" detected in
ambient speech ×31.
                no action (ambient, non-user).
```

```
20:44:00  SYSTEM     weather alert ingested:
thunderstorm, yellow
```

```
21:10:14  DOOR       front   OPEN
21:10:20  VOICE      speakers=3 (ASSUNTA, UNKNOWN_M1,
UNKNOWN_M2)
21:11:06  UTTERANCE  ASSUNTA  "l'ho mandata io ... su
al romito ... col pane ...
                     per mia madre"

class=EPISODE(temporal_disorientation)   conf=0.86
21:11:20  UTTERANCE  ASSUNTA  "bisogna andare prima che
arrivano i tedeschi"

class=EPISODE(temporal_disorientation)   conf=0.97
21:13:09  DOOR       front   CLOSED
21:13:10  NOTE       unknown voices present 21:10–21:13
(2). Carer not notified
                     (rule: visitors non-escalating).
```

```
21:40:51  POWER      interruption   (battery)
21:41:40  POWER      restored
21:44:30  VOICE      speakers=2 (ASSUNTA, GIUSEPPINA)
21:47:12  POWER      interruption   (battery)
21:47:55  POWER      restored
21:44 → 22:58   UTTERANCES ×44 ASSUNTA.  EPISODE ×29.
                top refs: MOTHER ×11 · BREAD/"pane" ×9
· IDA ×8 · ROMITO ×6
                · GERMANS/"tedeschi" ×4 · BEES/"api" ×3
```

```
· LEGS/"gambe" ×3
                distress (est.) 0.52–0.71
```

```
23:00:00  DIGEST     daily summary generated → CARER
(ROSA)   push: DELIVERED
                     opened: NO
```

Daily summary — Assunta, Tuesday 29 September

Assunta had a restless evening. She spent the afternoon with Ida, and they talked about school. Later she talked about her mother, about bread, and about the Germans. She said that she had sent Ida to the Romito with bread for her mother. (Note: Assunta's mother is recorded as deceased. This is likely to be a memory from the past.) Assunta did not eat her evening meal at the usual time. Giuseppina has been with her since 21:44.

Visitors today: Ida, Chiara, Giuseppina, 2 unknown. Episodes today: 37 (↑ 12 vs. 7-day average). Sleep: not yet detected.

Tip of the day: When your loved one talks about the past as though it is the present, try joining them there instead of correcting them. Ask about

the people and places they mention. You may learn something.

```
23:03:40  RADAR      ASSUNTA stand→walk→passage
gait=unsteady
23:03:58  RADAR      GIUSEPPINA seated, kitchen, no
movement (est. asleep)
23:04:11  DOOR       back   OPEN
23:04:11  WANDER     timer start   threshold 10:00
23:04:12  SENSOR     outdoor temp 7.1°C · rain heavy
23:11:30  DOOR       back   OPEN   (2nd)
23:11:52  VOICE      speakers=2 (GIUSEPPINA, ASSUNTA)
distant
23:13:20  DOOR       back   CLOSED
23:13:20  WANDER     timer stop   elapsed 09:09
threshold not met
                     escalate=NO
23:13:31  UTTERANCE  GIUSEPPINA  "madonna sunta ma che
fai ... con le api ...
                     sei fradicia"
23:14:02  UTTERANCE  ASSUNTA  "gliel'ho detto alle api"

class=EPISODE(temporal_disorientation)   conf=0.66
```

```
23:20 → 00:44   UTTERANCES ×17 ASSUNTA (low volume).
EPISODE ×15.
                AMBIENT: KEYWORD "IDA" ×88.
helicopter: not detected.
                generator noise from 23:30.
00:21:11  RADAR      GIUSEPPINA head on table   (sleep
```

```
likely)
00:44:10  RADAR      ASSUNTA seated, armchair, no
movement   (sleep likely)
00:45:00  SLEEP      onset detected (chair)   note: not
in bed
00:46:22  DOOR       front   OPEN
00:46:30  VOICE      speakers=2 (GIUSEPPINA, ROSA)
ROSA voice match 0.98
00:46:30  CARER      present
00:52:40  DOOR       front   CLOSED   (GIUSEPPINA
departs)
00:53 → 02:54   no speech.   RADAR: ROSA seated,
kitchen table, 121 min,
                minimal movement.  ASSUNTA asleep,
chair.
                AMBIENT: KEYWORD "IDA" ×41.
```

```
02:55:08  SLEEP      end   ASSUNTA
02:55:40  UTTERANCE  ASSUNTA  "mà"
                     class=EPISODE(misidentification)
conf=0.97
                     ref: deceased_relative(MOTHER) →
present_person(ROSA)
02:56:02  UTTERANCE  ROSA     "sì ... sono qua assù"
                     note: carer response non-
reorienting
02:56 → 02:59   UTTERANCES ×9 ASSUNTA.  EPISODE ×9.
                ref: MOTHER ×5 · BREAD ×3 · IDA (as "la
piccola", "la
                romana") ×3 · ROMITO ×2 · VAN ×1 · LEGS
×1
02:59:10  UTTERANCE  ROSA     "quando è andata assù"
02:59:14  UTTERANCE  ASSUNTA  "prima del buio ...
```

```
gliel'ho detto prima del buio"

class=EPISODE(temporal_disorientation)   conf=0.64
03:00:01  RADAR      ROSA stand→walk→madia   gait=fast
03:00:35  UTTERANCE  ROSA     "lei questo pane non lo
mangia ... non l'ha mai
                     mangiato in vita sua"
03:00:58  CALL       outbound (ROSA's device, not hub)
not logged
03:01 → 03:08   UTTERANCES ×31 ROSA (call).  KEYWORD
"IDA" ×4 ·
                "romito" ×3 · "pane" ×6
03:05:12  UTTERANCE  ROSA     "mamma ... l'albero ...
dov'è l'albero"
03:05:20  UTTERANCE  ASSUNTA  "ero nell'albero mà ...
dopo l'acqua ... dove gira
                     ... la pecora ... sono andata a
sinistra ... giù ... quello
                     grosso ... quello tagliato ...
scusami ... era così buio"

class=EPISODE(temporal_disorientation)   conf=0.52
                     ref: deceased_relative(MOTHER) →
present_person(ROSA)
03:06:01  UTTERANCE  ASSUNTA  "dentro faceva caldo ...
non ci crederesti"

class=EPISODE(temporal_disorientation)   conf=0.71
03:06:05  UTTERANCE  ROSA     "lo so mamma ... me l'hai
detto"
03:09:40  UTTERANCE  ASSUNTA  "signorina ... c'è rosa"
                     → WAKE   response: "Hello, Rosa."
03:10:15  UTTERANCE  ASSUNTA  "rosa ... la ragazzina è
tornata"
                     class=—
```

```
03:10:30  UTTERANCE  ROSA     "non ancora mamma ...
sono andati a prenderla"
03:11:02  UTTERANCE  ASSUNTA  "bene ... fa freddo
lassù"

class=EPISODE(temporal_disorientation)   conf=0.58
03:12:40  SLEEP      onset detected (chair)
```

```
03:13:00  REVIEW     night summary (automatic)
                     episodes 02:55–03:12: 14
                     distress (est.) peak 0.79 @
03:00:35 (CARER speech)
                     CARER present since 00:46   voice
match ROSA 0.98
                     escalation_policy: CARER PRESENT →
suppress
                     escalate=NO
```

```
03:20 → 06:00   no speech (user).  RADAR: ASSUNTA
asleep, chair.
                ROSA seated beside chair, 2 h 40 min,
minimal movement.
                AMBIENT: KEYWORD "IDA" ×0 after 03:50.
                vehicles departing ×3 (03:58, 04:21,
04:26).
                generator noise ends 05:12.
```

13

Chiara

03:36

The river was the loudest thing she had ever heard and after four hours she could no longer hear it.

That was the first thing the night had taught her. You stand beside a sound like that, a brown roaring muscle of water going under a stone arch with the whole weight of the mountain behind it, and for the first hour it is all there is; it fills your skull; you cannot think a sentence through to its end. And then, somewhere in the second hour, your mind gives up and lets it in, and it becomes the floor of the world, and you stand on it, and above it, quite clearly, you can hear everything else: a man coughing on the far bank; the hiss of the light towers; the radio on the fireman's shoulder; Lucia beside her, breathing through her mouth; your own heart. Your own voice, inside, going on and on, translating.

She had been translating all night. She could not stop. It was what her mind did with things it could not hold: it turned them into other things. *In piena*: in spate, in flood, full. *Sono piena*: I'm full, I've had enough, I can't. She had stood at the parapet of the bridge at midnight looking down at the men in their dry suits roped to the willows, holding long poles, going slowly along the margins of the water, pushing the poles into the dark places under the roots, the places where the current turned back on itself and things collected, branches, foam, a plastic

chair, and she had thought, very clearly, in English, *they are sounding*. The word you use for measuring depth. The word you use for how something seems. *How does it sound?* It sounds bad. It sounds very bad. *Sondare*. To probe. They were probing. And she had translated it and translated it until the words came apart in her hands like wet paper and she could see through them to the water, and then she had to go and sit in the fire engine with the door open and put her head between her knees.

Davide had rung eleven times. He was on the A24 at Avezzano with the road closed in front of him by a landslip, sitting in a queue of lorries with their engines off, and every time he rang she said *nothing*, and he said *nothing?*, and she said *nothing*, and the word was an object between them, small and smooth and heavy, that neither of them would put down.

The hat was in a plastic bag in the back of the carabinieri car. They had asked her to look at it, at eleven, and she had looked at it, and said yes, and they had taken it away again, and she had not asked for it back. She could not have held it. It was the first thing her mother had knitted since her father died. Red, because Ida had asked for red. Ida had worn it all through August, in the heat, refusing to take it off, and Chiara had said *you'll boil, amore*, and Ida had said *I like boiling*. It had been the colour of a postbox in Rome, the colour of the little Fiat that her grandfather drove, the colour of the warning triangle in the boot, the colour of the —

Stop.

. . .

At twenty to four Lalli came along the riverbank toward the bridge.

She saw him coming a long way off, in the glare of the lights, a short square man in a dark uniform jacket with the rain still shining on his shoulders, walking quickly but not running, and she knew from the way he was not running that it was not the thing. If it were the thing he would be walking slowly. She had worked this out at about one o'clock and had been watching the way men walked toward her ever since.

He came up onto the bridge. He had a notebook in his hand, closed, with his finger in it to keep a page.

"Signora," he said. "Come with me a moment, please. Away from the noise."

They went to the end of the bridge, where the road turned up into the village and there was a wall, and the river was a little further off. He did not take her arm. She was grateful for that.

"The daughter of your neighbour," Lalli said. "Rosa. She came tonight from Pescara, to be with her mother. She telephoned me forty minutes ago."

Chiara looked at him.

"Her mother woke up. She talked to her. About the bread." He opened the notebook, looked at it, closed it again, as if what was written there might have changed. "Signora, there is half a loaf of bread missing from Signora Assunta's house. The daughter says her mother doesn't eat that bread. The daughter says her mother gave it to Ida. And sent her up the mountain with it. To

the Romito. To bring it to —" he hesitated, very slightly — "to her mother."

She said: "Her mother."

"Signora Assunta's mother. Who died in the war."

And there it was, under the river, under the lights: an old woman's voice in a dark kitchen, peaceful, pleased with itself. *È ita a portà lu pane a mamma*. She heard it again exactly, every vowel, the way you hear a line you translated wrongly, long after, in the printed book, when it can no longer be changed.

She had sat beside the wrong sentence for eight hours.

"I asked her," Chiara said. Her voice came out very calm, very level, the voice she used for lawyers. "At a quarter to eight. I asked her where Ida was, and she told me. She told me twice."

"Signora."

"She told me and I said *thank you*. I said *grazie, Assunta*. I said *you shouldn't*. And then I went home."

"Signora, she told me too." Lalli's face was very tired and very kind and he did not look away from her. "At ten past nine. I wrote it down. I passed it on. It's on the board at the command post. She told everybody. And she also told me the Germans were coming, and she asked me if I was Concetta's son, and I am not anybody's son, Concetta's or anybody's in this valley, I am from Teramo." He breathed out through his nose. "And the dog stopped at the water, and the hat was in the river. It is not —"

He stopped himself. “It doesn’t matter now what it is. What matters is, there is a tree.”

“A tree.”

“Above the ford. Old. Hollow. Signora Assunta told her daughter where it is. Exactly where. And her daughter remembers a story, from when she was a girl, about her mother sheltering in it, in the war, in a storm. The daughter thinks — we think — that if Ida reached the Romito with the bread and then the storm came, she may have done the same. Because she was told to.” He looked at his notebook. “*If you can’t see the path, get in the tree*. That is what the daughter says her mother taught her. That is what she thinks her mother taught Ida.”

Chiara put her hand on the wall. The stone was wet and very cold. She held on to it.

“Two teams are going up now,” said Lalli. “By the forestry road from the pass, because the ford is still too high. CNSAS, Forestali, the dog handler. They’ll reach the Romito first, from above, and then come down the path toward the ford looking for the tree. They’ll be there before it’s light. The water is dropping. In two or three hours they may be able to cross the ford from this side too.”

“I’m coming.”

“Signora —”

“I’m coming with them.”

“Signora, there’s no room. Two vehicles, and they’re full, ropes, stretcher, medical, the dog. It’s fifty minutes of mud on a road that was half washed away last winter, and then a walk in the dark on a slope above a torrent in spate. If you come, they have to look after you as well. That is one person not looking for Ida.” He said it gently and without apology and she knew, as she had known in the bar, that it was correct, that it was the correct sentence and she was going to obey it, and she hated him for it with a clean, bright hatred that lasted about two seconds and then went out.

“So I wait.”

“So you wait.” He looked toward the village. “Not here. Not at the river. If they find her, and if the water’s down, they’ll bring her down the mulattiera — it’s the quickest way. To the cemetery. Wait at the cemetery gate, signora. Lucia will go with you. I’ll call the moment there’s anything. I’ll call you myself.”

“And if they don’t find her.”

He did not answer that. She had not expected him to. She found that she respected him for not answering it.

“*Her mother*,” Chiara said. “Assunta. Did she — what happened to her? In the war.”

“I don’t know, signora. Her daughter didn’t say. I don’t think her daughter knows.”

. . .

The vehicles left the square at four minutes to four. She heard them go, two engines grinding up the switchbacks above the village toward the pass, the sound going round and round the mountain and getting smaller, until it was only the river again.

She and Lucia walked up through the village. All the lights were on in all the houses. Old men stood in doorways in their coats and said nothing to her and touched their caps. In via del Forno, outside Assunta's, the big white dog was lying in the doorway of the empty house opposite with his chin on his paws, wet through, watching the top of the street. He lifted his head when Chiara passed and looked at her, and his nostrils worked, and then he put his head down again.

The kitchen window at Assunta's was lit. Chiara stopped. Through the glass, over the geraniums, she could see a small lamp, and the old woman asleep in the armchair under blankets, her face tipped back and her mouth open, and beside her, in a hard chair pulled close, a grey-haired woman in a good blouse with her coat in her lap, holding the old woman's hand. The grey-haired woman was not asleep. She was looking at the wall. She did not see Chiara at the window.

Chiara stood there for a long moment.

She wanted to go in. She wanted to go in and kneel down by the chair and say something to the old woman. She did not know what. *Sorry. Thank you. How dare you. Where is she*. She did not know which, or in which language, and she understood, standing in the cold street looking in at the lit window, that whatever she said, the old woman would not know who she

was, and would not remember it, and that it would be for herself, and she did not go in.

“Come, cara,” said Lucia, and took her arm.

. . .

The cemetery gate was iron and locked and above it the black cypresses went up into a sky with no light in it at all. Chiara sat on the low wall beside the gate with the thermal blanket round her shoulders crackling every time she breathed, and Lucia sat beside her and smoked, and in front of them the mulattiera went up between its broken walls into the dark and disappeared.

It was very cold. Far up in the cypresses something shifted and settled — birds — and was still.

Chiara looked up the path. She thought: she came this way. Her feet were on these stones. She thought: while it was still light. While I was saying *dovrebbe*. She thought: she walked up there on her own with her bag on her back and half a loaf of bread for a dead woman, because an old woman asked her to, and she said *va bene*. And she thought, for the first time all night not in translation, in no language at all: *of course she did*.

Her phone was in her hand. She held it so hard the edge hurt her palm.

Very slowly, at the top of the mountain, the sky began to be less black. Not grey. Only less. Then grey.

She waited.

14

The search

02:10 to 06:55

Operational log, PCA Pietrafonda, continued.

. . .

02:10–02:50 — VVF thermal drone (SAPR), Sector R, ford to confluence. Rain stopped. Returns: 2 × VVF fluvial operators (known), 1 × fox, 3 × small mammal. **No human signature in or beside the water.**

02:55 — Sector R ground search continuing. Fluvial team 2 (Pescara) on scene 02:40. Water level at bridge falling: −0.3 m from peak.

03:01 — Call to Brig. Lalli's mobile from **Rosa D.** (daughter of Assunta D.), now at via del Forno 4.

03:09 — Brig. Lalli to PCA coordinator, in person. Summary of call: - Assunta D., on waking, stated again that she gave the child bread and sent her to the Romito "before dark". - **Half a loaf of bread is missing**

from Assunta D.'s bread chest. Remaining half present, torn not cut. Daughter states her mother does not eat this bread. Not in bin, not on table. - Daughter states her mother told her (approx 1976) of sheltering overnight as a child in winter 1943 in **a hollow beech** above the ford on the Romito path, with the instruction to shelter in it "if you can't see the path". Daughter believes her mother may have told the child the same. - At 03:05 Assunta D., addressing her daughter as her mother, said where she had sheltered: "*after the water… where it turns… the sheep… I went left… down… the big one, the one they cut.*" Rosa D.'s interpretation: first hairpin above the ford, at the boulder known locally as *la pecora*; left of path (ascending); downhill; a large old pollard beech.

`03:12` — Coordinator: the missing bread is **physical corroboration** of the 21:14 statement. Timing consistent with dog (18:50 return) and trailing dog (indication at ford). Hat in river consistent with loss at ford, not necessarily entry into water. Bear tracks on far bank do not exclude a child having passed before.

`03:14` — Note: resident Franco D. recalled to PCA and asked about his route at 21:00–22:00. Confirms he passed the "sheep rock" ("*la pecora, sì, la conoscono tutti*") going up and coming down, calling. Did not

leave the path. Did not look at trees. “Why would we look at trees? We were calling her. She’d have answered.”

03:16 — **POA revised:** - **F** (forest above ford, incl. Romito + tree): **0.60** - **R** (river corridor): **0.20** - **M + V: 0.10** - **Outside: 0.10**

03:18 — Revised plan. **Team F1** (CNSAS ×4, Forestali ×1, trailing dog + handler) and **Team F2** (CNSAS ×3, VVF ×2, medical kit, vacuum stretcher) to depart by 4×4 via forestry road from Passo della Croce. Objective 1: Romito (confirm presence, look for sign). Objective 2: descend mulattiera from Romito to ford, locate “sheep rock” and candidate trees. Sector R search to continue at reduced strength.

03:22 — Forestali: forestry road partially obstructed at km 4.2 (landslip, 2025), passable with care. Expect 50–60 min to road end, then 400 m on foot to Romito.

03:40 — Brig. Lalli informs mother at stone bridge. Mother requests to join teams. Request declined (vehicle capacity, terrain, night). Mother advised to wait at cemetery gate at foot of mulattiera. Mother complies, accompanied by Lucia C.

03:56 — Teams F1, F2 depart PCA.

04:21 — Air support: VVF helicopter (Drago, Pescara) available from first light, approx 06:30, weather permitting. Low cloud on ridge.

04:30 — Mother's phone: child's father, delayed at Avezzano (A24 closed, landslip). Informed of new hypothesis.

04:52 — F1/F2 at end of forestry road. Track heavy, debris. Proceeding on foot with head torches. Calling child by name at intervals.

05:00–05:35 — VVF thermal drone, Sector F (upper), launched from Passo della Croce. Cloud base low. **Canopy closed** (beech, full leaf; first yellowing only). Returns through gaps: roe deer ×3; wild boar ×1; **large mammal + 2 small** moving upslope near cliff base approx 1,550 m (Forestali: consistent with bear, female with cubs; moving away from path); Teams F1/F2 (known). **No signature consistent with a child.** Drone operator notes: "*Under this canopy we only see what's in the gaps. If she's under a tree we won't see her. If she's inside one, nothing will.*"

05:09 — **F1 at Romito.** Cave mouth and hermit's cell searched. No child. **Found: on stone shelf beneath iron cross, among candle stubs from yesterday's**

procession, a half loaf of white bread wrapped in a tea towel. Dry (sheltered). End crust missing (torn). Bread placed upright, *"set out carefully, like something on an altar"* (F1 leader). Photo sent to PCA 05:11.

05:12 — Photo shown to Rosa D. by Brig. Lalli (by phone message). Rosa D. confirms the tea towel is her mother's (embroidered initials A.D.).

05:13 — **Child's presence at Romito confirmed.**

05:14 — Also found at Romito: on the dust of the stone floor, small shoe prints (trainer sole), several, partly overlaid by procession prints; candle-wax drip on floor below shelf with a small fingerprint in it. Bat droppings, fresh. No other sign.

05:16 — Trailing dog started at Romito shelf (scent article: pillowcase). Dog takes a trail out of the cave and **down the mulattiera**, slowly. Handler: trail very weak after rain; dog working from patches under rock overhang and dense litter. *"She's going down. That's all I can tell you."*

05:31 — F1, approx 200 m below Romito on mulattiera. Trailing dog loses trail on open wet scree. Casts, does not recover. Handler: *"Rain's taken it."* Teams continue down the path on foot, searching both sides, calling.

05:40 — F2: hollow beech approx 30 m left of path (descending), below a rock outcrop. Checked: **negative** (dormouse nest, old).

05:48 — F1: second hollow beech, large, approx 60 m right of path (descending). Checked with torch: **negative.**

05:53 — F1 leader to PCA: *"There are hollow beeches all over this slope. Half the old ones are hollow. And there are rocks everywhere and half of them look like sheep. We need the hairpin. We need the first hairpin above the ford, coming up. Coming down, that's the last. We're looking for the last hairpin."*

06:02 — Ford: water level falling fast; approx 0.4 m above normal. Sector R team 3 at near bank. Assess crossable with rope by approx 06:30.

06:11 — F1/F2 descending. Visibility improving (nautical twilight). Calling continuously. **No response.**

06:18 — Note (F2 leader): *"If she's here, she can hear us. We're loud. Either she's not here, or she's not able to answer, or she's choosing not to."* Coordinator requests medical readiness for hypothermia, possible injury.

06:22 — Brig. Lalli, by phone to F2 leader, passes on a point raised by Rosa D.: her mother's stories of the war include an instruction to *stay still and silent if you hear voices, "even if it's someone you know."* Daughter is uncertain whether her mother repeated this to the child. F2 leader acknowledges.

06:31 — Ford: Sector R team 3 crosses with rope. Two operators on far bank. Bear tracks of last evening still visible, partially washed. Start up mulattiera toward F teams.

06:36 — **Unaccompanied dog** observed by Sector R team 3 crossing the ford upstream of the rope, swimming the last metre, climbing the far bank: large, white, grey ears. Identified by Sandro P. (by phone) as the village dog ("Biscotto", "nobody's"). Dog goes up the mulattiera ahead of team 3 at a trot, nose down. Team 3 does not attempt to stop it.

06:40 — F1 at a hairpin with a large grey moss-topped boulder. F1 leader: "*Could be. Could be any of three.*" Calling. No response. Team spreads out across slope left of path (descending: right) to check trees.

06:47 — Sunrise in 18 minutes. Light under canopy still poor.

06:52 — Sector R team 3 by radio: “*The white dog’s left the path. Just above us, at a big rock. He’s gone off to the left, downhill, into the trees. Fast.*”

06:53 — F1 leader: “*Which rock?*”

06:55 — Sector R team 3: “*The one like a sheep.*”

15

The tree

All night the crown holds the rain.

It comes in a weight that the tree has felt five hundred times and that is nothing to it: the leaves taking the water and bowing under it and letting it go, down along the branches, down along the many arms of the old pollard, gathering in the crotches, running in a thin steady skin down the grey trunk and over the lips of the door and into the ground, where the roots take it. All night the trunk drinks. All night the wind leans on the full-leaf crown like a sail and the root-plate lifts its fingernail's width and settles, lifts and settles, the slope holding the tree and the tree holding the slope.

In the hollow, the warmth.

It does not keep still. It shifts in the red dust. It turns over. It makes small sounds that go into the wood and are nothing. For a while, early, it makes a long sound, high and broken, that goes on and on and then stops; and then for a while it is still; and then it shifts again. The dry wood around it receives it all equally. Inside the wall of the hollow, at the height of a sitting child, a small hard point scratches the dead inner wood, again and again, for some time, in short careful strokes. The tree does not feel it. It is the dead part. Nothing that happens to the dead part is a wound.

Feet on the path, early: two men, going up, heavy, quick, their voices going ahead of them, the same sound again and again, rising at the end. Then lightning near, and the men coming down, faster. The warmth in the hollow, while the feet pass, goes entirely still. As still as wood.

The feet go.

Later, the rain stops. The drip goes on.

Later still, outside the door, a breath. Something low, at the lip of the door, a wet nose pushed into the opening, drawing the air of the hollow in, in, in. A short hard sound further off, a cough like a slammed lid. The nose withdraws. Something heavy moves away up the slope through the litter, and two lighter somethings, and the forest floor feels them go.

Later still, in the hollow, a flicker of something passing the door very fast and turning away. A bat. In the hot months they hang in the narrow part above. Not now.

The warmth sleeps. It is possible to tell: the small sounds stop and the shifting stops and there is only the very slow rise and fall that goes into the wood with the regularity of water dripping. For hours. The warm body breathing in the red dust that was once the tree's heart, that the beetles made out of its heart, a hundred years of eaten heartwood lying soft in the bottom of a living tube on a mountain in the dark.

. . .

Then the light.

It starts where it always starts, at the top, in the leaves of the crown, before any of it reaches the floor. The first grey of it touches the uppermost leaves and the leaves begin, slowly, to open their pores; the tree begins, slowly, to draw water up; the whole slope, every beech, beginning at the same moment to drink, as if a single breath were being taken in by the mountain. It is the most ordinary thing the tree does. It has done it on every morning of its life.

Feet on the path. Many, this time, coming down from above. Voices, the same sound, rising at the end. Over and over, nearer.

In the hollow the warmth wakes, and goes still. As still as wood.

The voices come near. They pass along the path above, slowly. They come off the path, some of them, crunching through the litter among the trunks, and go to another tree, upslope, and stop, and go away again. The sound comes again and again. It is very close. The tree feels the feet in its long roots, which run under the slope in every direction like the threads under a carpet, and the feet are everywhere and nowhere, and the warmth in the hollow does not move at all.

Then, from below, from the direction of the water: other feet. Four of them. Light, quick, uneven, coming up the path at a trot and then leaving the path at the rock and coming straight down through the litter in the half-light, not stopping, not casting about, straight, the way water comes down a slope, the way a root goes toward water.

A nose at the door.

Pushing in. Not like the nose in the night, careful, drawing; this one comes in all the way, a head, shoulders, wet fur, heavy breath, the whole front of an animal shoved into the hollow, and the animal makes a sound, high, a whine, and the warmth in the bottom of the hollow says something back to it, a small sound, a word, and the animal's tail, outside the door, thumps against the lip of the bark, once, twice, three times, and the tree registers each blow as a small pressure on the lip of the old wound, which is nothing, which is weather.

Then the warmth moves.

It comes up out of the red dust. It pushes against the animal and the animal backs out and the warmth comes after it, through the door, a knee on the lip, a scrape, a hand on the rolled bark at the edge of the opening, holding hard, the whole small weight of a body hanging there for a moment from the tree. And then the weight is gone, out of the hollow, out into the grey light among the trunks; and the hollow is empty; and the air in it begins, at once, to cool.

Voices, then. Many. Loud. Feet coming fast through the litter. A high sound from the animal, over and over. A man's voice, very close, saying a single short thing, twice, in a voice that breaks.

The tree does not keep sounds.

The sun comes over the ridge and lands on the crown. All along the slope the beeches, which have been drinking since the grey, take it into their leaves; and the turning that has begun at the

tips of the crown, the gold, the struck-match colour, catches it, and for a minute the whole top of the tree is lit like something that has been set alight. Then the light moves down the slope and the colour is only the colour of leaves in autumn, which is what it is.

In the hollow, at the height of a sitting child, there is writing on the inner wall. Pencil. The tree has no record of it. It is on the part that is already dead, and the dead part does not grow, and so it will not widen with the years like the names on the bark; it will stay exactly the size it is now, in the dark, small and grey and careful, until the beetles come back for it, or the fungi, or the fire, or the long patience of the rot. That may be a hundred years.

The tree does not wait for anything. It drinks. It is morning. The light is on it.

16

The dog

The hour of the biscuit.

It is in him the way the hour of the bones is in him, the way the hour of the bins behind the bar on the morning the lorry comes is in him: a hook, low in the belly, that starts to pull before the light. Every morning in the grey, when the doors open and the small ones come out of them with their bags, biscuit-girl comes out of hers and down the street and he is there, at the corner, where he has been since before she came out, and she says the sound, *Biscotto*, and her hand comes down, and in the hand is the yellow one.

Every morning. This is a thing that is true.

The light is not here yet. But the hook is.

. . .

He has been lying in the doorway across from the old woman's all night with his chin on his paws.

He went to the bones, when the light went, at the back door of the bar, and stood over them, and did not eat them, and came here. He lay in the doorway because it was out of the rain and because from the doorway he could smell everything: the old

woman's house with the old woman in it, asleep, and then the old woman's daughter, who came in the night smelling of a car and the far city by the sea and fear, and the street, and the men coming and going in the street with their fear, all the men, all night, so much fear on them that the whole village smelled of it, a sour grey fog lying in the streets with the rain.

And the strange dog. Heavy, long-eared, loose-lipped, slow, from a car, from a far place, with a man holding it on a long line. It came up the street in the night with its nose down and went to biscuit-girl's door and then to the old woman's door and then up, up the street, toward the place of the stones, toward the path, following her. He stood up when it passed. Every hair. It did not look at him. It was working. It went up the path into the dark with its man, and a long time later it came back down with its man, and its man was saying *niente* and the strange dog was wet to the shoulders and smelled of the cold green water and of having stopped.

He lay down again. He did not follow it. He knew where it had stopped. He had stopped there too.

. . .

Now the hook.

He gets up. Shakes. Goes up the street. Past the place of the stones, where a woman is sitting on the wall with a crackling silver thing round her shoulders, and another woman beside her with smoke. He knows the first one. Biscuit-girl's mother.

She smells of biscuit-girl, a little, the house-smell, and of salt, and of the fear more than anyone, so thick on her he has to put his ears back going past. She looks at him. She does not say a sound to him. He goes on. On to the path. Up.

The trees. The cold.

The night is all over the path, all of it lying there in layers: the men going up and the men coming down, and the strange dog going up and the strange dog coming down, and blood, a little, a man's, on a stone, and the rain over all of it, flattening it, washing it into the cracks. Under that the morning, the whole village, the blanket, gone thin. Under that biscuit-girl going up yesterday, faint, faint, washed nearly out, a ghost of a ghost. He follows it anyway. It is going the way he is going.

The water.

It is still loud. It is still fast and brown and high on the stones. But it is lower than it was in the night — he can smell where it was, the wet line on the bank above the water where everything smells new-drowned — and there are men at it with a rope, two of them on the far side already, and the men on this side see him and one says *eh*, *guarda*, il *cane*, and nobody says *vattenne*.

He does not use the stones. He goes in above them where it is slower, and the cold closes over his shoulders and the water takes him and he swims, hard, crooked, the bank coming toward him sideways, and his feet find it, and he is out, and up, and shaking, and the far bank is all around him.

Big one: old now. Last night's. Washed. Still there, still *no*, the hair on his neck going up by itself and then lying down again, because it is old, because it is going the other way, up, away.

And biscuit-girl.

. . .

Here is the thing.

On the path she is almost gone. The rain has taken her. But the path is not the only thing. The air is moving. At this hour, before the sun, the air on the mountain comes down: the whole slope breathing out, a slow cold slide of air going downhill through the trees toward the water, carrying with it everything it has passed over. And he stands on the far bank with his nose up and the air comes down to him through the trunks and in it, faint, but not old, not a ghost, not yesterday —

Now.

Biscuit-girl now. Warm. Wool and salt and soap and the inside of her shoes and the old woman on her hands still, and wood, and dust, and —

The yellow one.

He goes.

. . .

Up the path. Fast. The men behind him calling something, not to him. Up past the first turn and the big grey rock, and the air coming down the slope is thicker here, it is coming from the left, from below the rock, from among the trees. He leaves the path. Down through the dead leaves and the empty husks, straight, nose up, not casting, not stopping, the smell getting louder and louder until it is the only thing, until it is a wall, until it is a tree.

A big one. Many arms. A hole at the bottom.

The smell is coming out of the hole.

He puts his head in.

Dark, and dry, and the red dust, and her. Right there. Folded up in the bottom of the hole like a cat in a box, her eyes open, very still. Very still. More still than a live thing. She smells of the night and of cold and of having been afraid for a long time and then of being too tired to be afraid. She smells of the biscuit.

He makes a sound. He doesn't decide to make it.

She says: *Biscotto.*

The come-sound.

His tail goes. It hits the tree. He can't stop it. He pushes his head further in, his shoulders, and she puts her hands on his face, both hands, cold, and pushes, and he backs out, and she comes out after him, all knees and elbows, into the grey, and stands up, and staggers, and puts her arms round his neck and her face into the wet of his neck, and holds on, hard, the way nobody

holds on to him, and he stands there and lets her, because she is holding on, because her hands are there.

Then she lets go and takes the bag off her back.

He knows this. He sits. He doesn't need to be told to sit; he sits the way he sits at the corner every morning, square, with his front feet together, looking at the bag.

She opens it. She takes out the yellow one.

He takes it from her hand very gently, the way he always does, and eats it.

Behind them, coming down through the trees, the men, loud, and one of them shouting a sound, again and again, and the sound breaking in half. Biscuit-girl turns her head toward them. She looks at the men coming. She looks at him. She puts her hand on his head and leaves it there.

He finishes the biscuit and looks at her hand to see if there is another one. There isn't.

It is morning. That is the hour. The hook in his belly, which has been pulling all night, goes slack.

17

The search

06:57 to 07:53

Operational log, PCA Pietrafonda, concluded.

. . .

06:57 — Sector R team 3 by radio: **child located.** Hollow beech approx 45 m below "sheep rock", left of mulattiera (ascending). Child out of the tree, standing, with the village dog. Conscious. Walking.

06:58 — F1 converging from above.

06:59 — Team 3 operator to PCA (voice, verbatim): "È *lei*. È *viva*. È *lei*."

07:00 — Coordinator confirms to all stations: **TROVATA. VIVA.** Found. Alive.

07:01 — Brig. Lalli informs mother by phone at cemetery gate. Call duration 0:41.

07:04 — F1 on scene. Medical assessment (CNSAS): core temperature (tympanic) **35.3 °C**: mild hypothermia. Clothing damp, socks wet. Abrasion to left knee, minor. No other injuries. Alert, oriented to person, place and time. Hungry. Thermal blanket, dry fleece, warm sweet drink. Child declines vacuum stretcher. Will be carried.

07:05 — Sunrise.

07:06 — Air support stand-down. Sector R teams recalled.

07:08 — Child states she heard the team calling her name during the night and this morning. Did not answer.

07:11 — F1 leader to PCA, note for file: "*She's fine. She's cross. She wants her breakfast. She says the tree was warm.*"

07:14 — Descent begins via mulattiera. Village dog accompanies team at heel of operator carrying child. Cannot be dissuaded. Not dissuaded.

07:19 — F2, at request of F1 leader, photographs the interior of the hollow beech for the file. Interior dry; deep layer of red wood dust; child's impression in dust;

on inner wall at approx 0.7 m, **pencil marks** (writing; not legible in photograph; to be checked). Not checked. Teams descending.

07:36 — Ford. Water level 0.2 m above normal. Child carried across on rope line. Dog swims.

07:51 — Team and child at cemetery gate.

07:52 — **Child handed to mother.**

07:53 — Prefettura informed. **Search concluded.** Personnel deployed overnight: 74 (VVF 23, CNSAS 19, Carabinieri 9, Carabinieri Forestali 6, Protezione Civile 9, canine 2, residents 6+). Duration: 11 h 32 min from 112 call.

18

The crows

Grey-light. We wake. We say what is known.

The night was wrong. All of us say it at once, from every cypress, loud: the night was wrong. Lights where there are no lights, white, on poles, down at the water. A roaring that did not stop. Faces all night in the street and at the water and on the path, many, with lights on their heads, calling. The dogs. A strange dog, not ours, heavy, long-eared. The big noise-thing in the sky did not come. Wrong, wrong. It is told, it is told, it is told, until it is put away.

Then quiet. We sit in the tops of the trees with the wet on our backs and look down.

At the gate of the place of the stones, on the wall, two faces.

One is known: the one who puts out bones behind the bar. Gives. She has the smoke. The other is the small face's mother-face, from the house beside the bent one. We have seen her before, always at the window, always looking down at the shining box on her table. Neither. Now she is not at the window. She is on the wall at the gate with a silver thing round her that crackles, and she does not move, and her face is turned up the path where the trees close, and has been turned that way since the dark. We look at it. We learn it. It is a face like the bark of a tree after the rain. It is a face that has been looking at one place for a long time.

The dog goes past. Up. Fast. Into the trees.

We say nothing about the dog. The dog is nuisance.

. . .

The light comes. The sun gets over the mountain and lands on the tops of the cypresses first, on us, before anything else in the valley. We open our wings in it. We would go down now to the stubble and the bins and the river and the day. But some of us do not go. Some of us stay on the cypresses, a few, with one eye on the place where the trees close.

We do not know why. Nothing is owed.

Then, on the path, coming out of the trees: faces.

Many. Orange and yellow, bright, the colours that shout. Ropes. Boxes on their backs. Slow. And among them, high up, carried on the shoulders of a big face, held — small. Wrapped in silver. A red face, from cold, a small one, looking about.

Looking up.

At us.

And it says the sound. It says it up at the cypresses, at the one with the white feather in his wing, who is on the lowest branch where he always is, too close, where he has been all night. It says it the way it always says it, as if nothing has happened, as if

it is any morning at the edge of the school-noise with a crust in its hand:

Bianchino.

The one with the white feather puts his head on one side.

. . .

At the gate the mother-face is up off the wall. The silver thing falls off her. She does not go to the faces coming down; she cannot; she stands at the gate as if the ground has hold of her feet. It is the faces who come to her. The big face takes the small one off his shoulders and puts it down and it stands, and staggers, and the mother-face comes forward then, two steps, and goes down. On her knees. On the wet stones. So her face is the height of the small face.

And they press together. The two faces. Close, closer than faces go, until they are not two shapes but one shape, at the gate, among all the bright faces standing back from it in a ring, quiet.

The mother-face makes a sound. It is not a call. It is not a sound we have. It goes on for a long time.

The dog sits down beside them on the wet stones, square, with his front feet together, and looks at nothing.

. . .

What is known:

The small face went up the path at the wrong time and did not come down in the dark, and came down in the light, carried. Gives. Small. Looks. Has a sound for one of us. Is kept.

The mother-face: we watch it, in the ring of the bright faces, at the gate, pressed into the small one. We have no verdict. We will watch it. We will see if it comes to the wall.

19

Transcript

```
DEVICE   CURA·home hub v3.2   SN 0417-PF-2219
SITE     via del Forno 4, Pietrafonda (AQ)
LOG      04/10   16:41 → 17:12   VOICE TRANSCRIPT
(full)
LANG     it → en (auto)   dialect segments: low
confidence
EXPORT   requested 06/10 22:47 by CARER (ROSA)   note:
"keep"
```

· · ·

ASSUNTA — What happened to your knee? `class=–`

IDA — The tree. I told you yesterday.

ASSUNTA — Did you? Tell me again. I like stories. `class=–`

IDA — Okay. But you have to listen properly this time.

ASSUNTA — I always listen properly. *[laughter]*
`class=HUMOUR conf=0.55`

IDA — So I went up the way behind the cemetery like you said. And Biscotto came. And it was really far, Nonna. You didn't say it was so far. In the morning it wasn't far because everyone was talking and there was the band, but on your own it's far. And it gets dark really fast in the trees, it gets dark in the trees before it gets dark everywhere else, did you know that?

ASSUNTA — Yes. `class=–`

IDA — You should have said. And at the water my hat fell in. The red one. My nonna in Rome made it and it went right down the river and the firemen found it, so that's okay, but it's all — it's gone stiff. And Biscotto wouldn't come over. He just barked and barked. He's a coward.

ASSUNTA — Dogs know things. `class=–`

IDA — He doesn't know anything. He's a dog. So I went up on my own and I got to the Romito and there wasn't anybody there.

[pause 00:00:04]

IDA — Just the candles from the morning. And the cross. And it was really cold and dark inside. And the water coming out of the wall, drip, drip. So I put the

bread on the shelf, under the cross, with the candles, so it would be like — so it would look nice. And I said it. What you told me. *Ecco, Mà. Sono arrivata.* And I said *Mà* properly this time, not like before, I practised it all the way up. *Mà*. Like that. Like a sheep.

ASSUNTA — *[inaudible]* `ASR conf=0.12`

IDA — And nobody said anything. Obviously.

IDA — I didn't know if I was supposed to wait. You didn't say if I was supposed to wait. So I waited for a bit. And then I ate the end bit. Of the bread. Only the end bit, the crust, because I was starving, because I didn't have my snack because the snack was the bread. Sorry.

ASSUNTA — The end bit's the best bit. `class=–`

IDA — I know.

IDA — And then it started thundering and I went to come back down but it was so dark I couldn't see the path, I couldn't see *anything*, Nonna, I couldn't see my hand, and I was scared, a bit, not very, and then I remembered what you said, about the tree. And I found it. It was where I saw it in the morning, where the path goes round and there's the big rock like a

sheep, and you go left and down a bit. I put my head in it in the morning. Giuseppina pulled me out. She said there's mice.

ASSUNTA — There's mice. `class=–`

IDA — There weren't any mice. And it wasn't *that* warm. You said it was warm like the inside of a loaf. It wasn't. You exaggerated.

ASSUNTA — *[laughter]* I exaggerate everything.
`class=HUMOUR conf=0.71`

IDA — It was a *bit* warm. Warmer than outside. And there's all this red stuff on the bottom, like powder, soft, like flour but red, and you can sort of make a nest. And I had my jacket. But my sock was wet, the left one, from the water, and I couldn't take it off because then my foot would be bare, so I just had a wet sock all night, the whole night, and it was horrible. That was the worst thing actually. The sock.

[pause 00:00:03]

IDA — I counted to a thousand. Twice. And I did the planets. Eight. Not five.

ASSUNTA — Five. `class=HUMOUR conf=0.48`

IDA — *Eight*. And I was really cross with you. I want to tell you that. I was really cross with you the whole time. Because it was so far and so dark and you didn't say, and nobody was even there, and my sock.

ASSUNTA — Good. Be cross. `class=–`

IDA — I'm not cross now.

ASSUNTA — Be cross a bit. It keeps you warm. `class=–`

IDA — And in the night something came. Outside the door. It breathed really loud, like — *[sniffing sound]* — like that, but bigger. I thought it was Biscotto. But it smelled different. Like a wardrobe. Like an old wardrobe that's been shut. And then there was a noise like a door slamming, and it went away.

[pause 00:00:06]

ASSUNTA — *[inaudible]* `ASR conf=0.09`

IDA — And a thing flew past. Whoosh. Really fast. And then I went to sleep.

IDA — And the men came. Twice. In the night when it was thundering and then in the morning. Shouting *Ida*, *Ida*. And I stayed still. Like a stone. Like you said.

Even when they said my name. I was really good at it. I didn't move at all, not even my wet foot.

[pause 00:00:11]

ASSUNTA — Next time, you shout. `class=–`

IDA — But you said —

ASSUNTA — Next time you shout. You shout so loud they hear you in Pescara. You hear me? You shout so loud they hear you in *America*. `class=–`

IDA — Okay.

ASSUNTA — Promise. `class=–`

IDA — Okay. I promise. But Biscotto came first anyway, before the men. And Biscotto isn't someone, so I came out. And I gave him my biscuit.

ASSUNTA — Brava. `class=–`

[pause 00:00:05]

IDA — I wrote in the tree.

ASSUNTA — What did you write? `class=–`

IDA — With my pencil from my pencil case. On the inside, on the wood.

IDA — It's for the next person. Not you.

ASSUNTA — *[laughter]* Did you spell it right? `class=HUMOUR conf=0.33`

IDA — Mostly.

[pause 00:00:09]

ASSUNTA — And Mamma?
`class=EPISODE(temporal_disorientation) conf=0.88 ref: deceased_relative(MOTHER)`

ASSUNTA — Did she get it? The bread?
`class=EPISODE(temporal_disorientation) conf=0.93`

[pause 00:00:07]

IDA — I said it like you said. *Ecco, Mà, sono arrivata.* Really properly. So she knows.

IDA — And the firemen found the bread in the morning, it was still there on the shelf where I put it. So maybe she wasn't hungry.

[pause 00:00:14]

ASSUNTA — No. `class=–`

ASSUNTA — She was never hungry. She said. Every night. *I'm not hungry, Assù, you have it.*
`class=EPISODE(temporal_disorientation) conf=0.61`

[pause 00:00:21]

ASSUNTA — Have you been to the bees?
`class=EPISODE(perseveration?) conf=0.40`

IDA — No. Can we go? Can we go and tell them? That I'm back?

ASSUNTA — Tell them? `class=–`

IDA — You have to tell them things. Otherwise they leave.

ASSUNTA — Who told you that? `class=–`

IDA — You did. You tell them everything. I hear you over the wall. You told them about the saint, and about Giuseppina's pressure, and about the Mancinelli boy moving to Castel di Sangro. You told them Saturn's got a hat.

ASSUNTA — *[laughter]* `class=HUMOUR conf=0.90`

IDA — Come on. I'll help you with your legs.

```
17:12:04  RADAR      ASSUNTA stand→walk   IDA walk
gait=slow, assisted
17:12:30  DOOR       back   OPEN
17:12:31  VOICE      speakers=0
```

Field notes

What is true in this book, what is uncertain, and what is invented.

Every mind in *The Errand* was written from what is actually known about how that kind of mind perceives the world. The biologist Jakob von Uexküll called this a creature's *Umwelt*: the slice of reality its senses and needs make available to it. A tick's world, he said, is made of three signals: the smell of butyric acid, warmth and the texture of hair. Everything else in the universe, for the tick, does not exist.

These notes say where each chapter stands on solid ground, where it stands on the edge of current knowledge, and where it steps off into imagination. Sources are listed at the end of each section. Where I relied on general knowledge rather than a source checked while writing, I say so.

THE CROWS

Hooded crows (*Corvus cornix*), the grey-bodied crows with black hoods, are the common village crow of

central and southern Italy. In autumn and winter they gather at dusk in communal roosts in tall trees, and the noise they make settling (which sounds like quarrelling) peaks at dusk and falls away into silence.

The crows' "archive of faces" is based on John Marzluff's experiments at the University of Washington. Researchers wearing a particular rubber mask trapped and banded seven crows. For at least five years afterwards, crows scolded anyone wearing that mask, while ignoring a neutral one. The knowledge spread to crows that had never been trapped, including young birds and birds up to 1.2 km away, through observation. Crows can learn a dangerous face from other crows and pass it on. Similar face recognition has been found in magpies and mockingbirds.

So-called "crow funerals" (crows gathering noisily around a dead crow) are now thought by researchers to be about learning danger, not mourning. My crows don't mourn. They learn.

Birds generally have four types of colour receptor, including one sensitive to violet or ultraviolet light, so they see colours humans can't. The detail of Ida's schoolbag "shining in the colour the faces cannot see" is an extrapolation: many synthetic fabrics contain optical

brighteners that interact with UV light. I haven't found a study of corvids and children's rucksacks.

Sources: Marzluff and colleagues' mask studies, reported in *National Wildlife* (2013) and elsewhere; Swift & Marzluff (2015) on responses to dead conspecifics; general ornithology for roost behaviour and avian vision (not separately verified).

THE DOG

A dog has somewhere between 125 and 300 million olfactory receptor cells, depending on the breed, against about 5–6 million in a human. Air leaves a sniffing dog's nose through the slits at the sides, creating swirls that draw fresh scent into the centre of each nostril, so a working dog can inhale almost continuously. The organ in the roof of a dog's mouth (the vomeronasal organ) detects chemical signals, which is why "the roof of his mouth tasting" in chapter 3 isn't only metaphor.

The idea that **a dog perceives time through smell** (old smells are faint, new smells are strong, and the air coming toward you carries what is about to arrive)

comes from the cognitive scientist Alexandra Horowitz. It's an argument, not a laboratory finding, but it's a well-grounded one. Trailing dogs do determine a person's direction of travel from the difference in scent strength between footsteps.

Dogs can detect human stress: in a 2022 study, four dogs distinguished breath and sweat samples taken from people before and after a stressful task with about 94% accuracy. That's why, in this book, the whole village "smelled of fear".

The dog's behaviour at the ford (following Ida to the water and losing her scent there) is how scent dogs really behave at running water. A trailing dog arriving later will indicate at the water's edge and refuse to go further. Searchers read that as "the trail ends here". It doesn't mean the person entered the water. It means the dog can't tell. Cool, still, humid air holds scent close to the ground, and dense leaf litter under a canopy can preserve it surprisingly well, which is why the dog can pick up Ida in the downhill night air at dawn. The descending night breeze on mountain slopes (katabatic flow) is real.

The village dog's fear of bear scent is invented but plausible. Maremmano-Abruzzese sheepdogs, the region's great white guardian breed, are bred to

confront wolves and bears. My dog is a mongrel with some of that blood and none of that training.

Sources: Horowitz, *Inside of a Dog* (2009); Wilson et al. (2022), *PLOS ONE*; Craven, Settles et al. on canine nasal airflow; general search-and-rescue practice (not separately verified for running water).

THE BEES

A honeybee colony holds its brood nest at about 35°C, and the margin is narrow. Brood reared below about 32°C develops crumpled wings and malformed legs. Bees generate the heat by shivering their flight muscles without moving their wings. In autumn the colony tightens around the last brood of the year.

Bees can detect weak electric fields. Bumblebees use them to tell which flowers have recently been visited (Clarke et al., 2013, *Science*), sensing them through the mechanical movement of their body hairs. Honeybees perceive electric charges, including those on other dancing bees (Greggers et al., 2013). The atmosphere's electric field changes sharply before a thunderstorm. **Whether a hive actually senses an approaching storm**

through this channel isn't established. Beekeepers widely say bees "know" a storm is coming and rush home; I used that, and the chapter's opening is an extrapolation.

Bees sense vibration through organs in their legs (the subgenual organs), which is how a knock on the hive reaches every bee standing on comb. A hive that's knocked answers with a collective hissing buzz; beekeepers know the sound well. The idea that the bees "do not keep" what Assunta tells them is simply true: a comb stores honey, pollen and brood, and a dance is a message about now.

"Telling the bees" (reporting births, deaths and departures to the hives, often with a knock, so that they don't leave or die) is documented in England, Ireland, Wales, Germany, the Netherlands, France, Switzerland, Bohemia and the Basque Country. I found **no record of it as an Italian tradition**, so in the novel Assunta learned it as a child, watching her grandmother quietly follow the advice of an escaped English prisoner of war whom the family sheltered in autumn 1943. That detail is invented. The history around it isn't: thousands of Allied prisoners escaped from Italian camps after the armistice of September 1943, and many were hidden and fed by mountain villagers at great risk.

Sources: Bristol University press releases on Clarke et al. (2013) and Sutton et al. (2016, *PNAS*); Greggers et al. (2013); literature on brood thermoregulation; Wikipedia and Basque ethnographic sources on telling the bees.

THE BAT

The lesser horseshoe bat (*Rhinolophus hipposideros*) lives in caves, old buildings and hollow trees in the Abruzzo mountains. It echolocates with a long, constant-frequency call at about 110 kHz, far beyond human hearing, emitted through its nose and shaped by the horseshoe-shaped noseleaf.

Horseshoe bats do something remarkable. As they fly forward, the echoes returning from objects ahead would be raised in pitch by the Doppler effect. The bat continuously **lowers its own call** to compensate, so the echoes always return at the precise frequency where its hearing is most acute. Against that steady background, the beating wings of an insect create tiny rhythmic flickers in the echo, which the bat detects as "glints". That's why, in chapter 10, a moth is "a flicker in the pitch." The same sensitivity could in principle register

the slow rise and fall of a sleeping child's chest; that's my extrapolation.

Rain masks echoes and attenuates high frequencies, so bats forage much less in rain. The chapter's bat waits until the storm has passed.

The chapter is a response to the philosopher Thomas Nagel's 1974 essay "What Is It Like to Be a Bat?" Nagel argued that a bat surely has an experience, that there is *something it is like* to be a bat, but that its sonar is so unlike any human sense that we can't imagine it from the inside. Imagining flying and hanging upside down only gives us what it would be like for *us* to behave like a bat. The chapter takes that seriously. It uses human words like *glitter* and *sparkle* because there are no others, and lets the reader notice that they're wrong.

Sources: Salari et al. (2015) and a Pensoft checklist on Abruzzo bat species; bat survey literature on horseshoe call frequencies; a 2022 *Frontiers in Ecology and Evolution* paper on rain and bat activity; Nagel (1974), *The Philosophical Review*.

THE BEAR

The **Marsican brown bear** (*Ursus arctos marsicanus*) is a small, genetically isolated population of brown bear that lives only in the central Apennines. A genetic census in summer 2025, using 608 hair samples snagged on wire and DNA to identify individuals, estimated **81 bears** (range 73–88): 43 females and 38 males. The whole subspecies could sit in a village hall.

In autumn the bears enter **hyperphagia**, eating for most of their waking hours to build fat for hibernation. A study of more than 2,300 droppings found that in autumn about two-thirds of their diet is hard mast (beechnuts and acorns) and about a quarter is fleshy fruit. Beech produces heavy crops only every few years, and in a poor mast year bears turn to orchards and village edges. That's why my sow has been in the plums. (I didn't find a study confirming plums specifically in the Marsican diet; orchard raiding is widely reported.)

Marsican bears are known as unusually unaggressive toward people. But a female with cubs is the configuration where caution is greatest, which is why the searchers in this book stay out of the forest at night. The sow's behaviour (smelling the child, calling her cub back with a huff and a clap of the jaws, and leaving) is what a bear does: avoidance. Bears really do communicate with huffs and jaw-popping.

Two famous Marsican bears appear obliquely in this book. **Juan Carrito**, a young male who became famous for walking into the ski town of Roccaraso and raiding a pastry shop, was killed by a car on the SS17 near Castel di Sangro in January 2023. His mother, **Amarena**, was shot dead in August 2023 by a man who said he fired "out of fear" when she appeared on his property; her cubs were orphaned. Italy mourned them both. The sow in this book "remembers" a young bear's scent ending on a road. That's my invention, and my small memorial.

Several villages around the national park have rebuilt parts of themselves around the bears: bear-proof bins, electric fences around hives and henhouses, metal doors on outbuildings. That's why my sow has never reached Assunta's honey: "the wire there bites."

Sources: ISPRA and press coverage of the 2025 DigitAP census; Ciucci et al. (2014), *Journal of Mammalogy*; ANSA and *Wanted in Rome* on Juan Carrito and Amarena; Rewilding Europe and Fondation Segré on Bear Smart Communities.

THE TREE

The ancient beech forests of the Abruzzo, Lazio and Molise National Park, including Val Cervara and Selva Moricento, are part of the UNESCO World Heritage site *Ancient and Primeval Beech Forests of the Carpathians and Other Regions of Europe*. Beeches in Val Cervara have been dated to around 500 years, and park sources claim more than 560: twice the age usually reported for the species, and among the oldest known beeches in the northern hemisphere. My tree is about 500 years old.

Everything the tree "does" in chapter 5 is real biology: - **Waiting.** Beech seedlings can survive for decades in deep shade, growing almost nothing, until a gap opens in the canopy. - **Senses.** Trees sense gravity through starch grains in specialised cells, grow toward light, and thicken where the wind bends them. - **Hollowing.** Old beeches often survive with hollow trunks. The tree walls off decay chemically (compartmentalisation), lets fungi consume the dead heartwood, and carries on living in a tube of outer wood, which is mechanically strong. - **Drought clicks.** Under drought, the water columns in a tree's vessels can snap, forming bubbles. Each event produces a tiny ultrasonic click, inaudible to humans. - **Writing in the bark.** Beech bark is thin and smooth and doesn't shed, so names carved into it remain for the life of the tree and widen as it grows. -

Pollarding. Old trees cut back for charcoal or fodder regrow "many-armed".

About the "**wood wide web**": popular books describe trees sharing sugar and warnings through underground fungal networks, with "mother trees" feeding their offspring. A 2023 review by Justine Karst and colleagues argued that much of this goes well beyond the evidence. Fungal networks connecting tree roots do exist, and carbon can move through them, but whether this matters to trees and whether "mother trees" favour kin is, they found, unsupported by peer-reviewed evidence. (Other researchers have disputed parts of the review.) So my tree "cannot argue. If it is connected to the others, it does not know. If it is alone, it does not know that either."

The earthquakes the tree feels are real. Avezzano, on 13 January 1915, killed about 30,000 people. L'Aquila, on 6 April 2009, killed 309. They were ninety-four years apart.

Sources: UNESCO World Heritage documentation; Schirone et al. on Val Cervara; Karst, Jones & Hoeksema (2023), *Nature Ecology & Evolution*, and a 2024 rebuttal in *Frontiers in Forests and Global Change*; studies of acoustic emissions in xylem; Shigo's work on compartmentalisation (general knowledge).

ASSUNTA, AND THE CARE DEVICE

Assunta's dementia follows real patterns. Recent memory fails first while older memory persists, so a person may come to live in an earlier decade, look for people long dead, or feel an urgent need to complete a task from the past ("I have to collect the children from school"). **Sundowning**, increased agitation and confusion in late afternoon and evening, is common, though its causes are debated. Sudden pockets of lucidity, sometimes about deep memories, are widely reported by carers, though not well understood. Assunta's precise directions at 3am fall into that territory: possible, strange and unexplained.

There are two broad approaches to someone living in the past. **Reality orientation** gently restates the facts ("your mother died in 1943"). It's thought useful in early stages and potentially distressing later, because each correction can mean a fresh bereavement. **Validation**, developed by Naomi Feil, accepts the emotional reality of what the person says and joins them in it. A Cochrane review found insufficient evidence that validation therapy works as a formal method, yet many carers find its spirit humane. Rosa's inability to say "the bread got there" and Ida's ease in doing something like it are the

book's quiet argument about that difference, which it doesn't resolve.

The care device is fictional, but every capability it has exists in real products or research systems: radar-based fall and movement detection without cameras, door and bed sensors, voice assistants, automated daily summaries for family carers, and rules that decide when to raise an alarm. Its main limitation is also real: speech recognition performs badly on dialect, older voices and distant speech. Its classifications (*episode*, *temporal disorientation*, *confidence* 0.91) are my invention, as is the idea that such a device would tag a confused statement as confusion even when it's true. I don't know of any system that does exactly this. I'd be surprised if none did.

Sources: Feil's validation method and the Cochrane review (CD001394); a 2025 *JMIR Aging* systematic review of remote monitoring in dementia; industry descriptions of radar fall detection.

THE SEARCH

The search follows Italian procedure as reported in real cases. A 112 call is passed to the Carabinieri. The provincial Prefettura activates the *piano provinciale per la ricerca di persone scomparse*, and there's no waiting period for a missing child. Then come the Vigili del Fuoco (fire service, including swift-water and drone units), the CNSAS (alpine and cave rescue), the Carabinieri Forestali, Protezione Civile volunteers and trailing dogs (*cani molecolari*). Thunderstorms ground helicopters, and thermal drones can't see through a closed canopy, let alone into a hollow trunk.

The "probability of area" table is a real search-management tool: teams assign each sector a probability that the person is there and revise it as clues arrive. The figures in the book are mine. So is the fact that the decisive clue at 3am is half a loaf of bread missing from a bread bin.

The night-time temperatures (5–9°C at ~1,000 m in late September, a mean September minimum of about 6.4°C at nearby Pescasseroli) and Ida's mild hypothermia (35.3°C after a night in a damp sock) are realistic. A child who stays dry and out of the wind, as she does in the tree, can survive such a night.

Children who are lost often don't respond to searchers calling their names, from fear, shame, or having been

told not to talk to strangers. Search-and-rescue teams are trained to *look*, not only to call.

Sources: Italian press reports of real searches (Serle, Brescia; Anterselva, South Tyrol; a night search near Campobasso); general search-and-rescue practice (not separately verified).

THE WAR

In autumn 1943, after Italy's armistice with the Allies, German forces occupied central Italy and held the **Gustav Line** across Abruzzo along the river Sangro. Villages in the front zone were forcibly evacuated, and some were destroyed; Roccaraso was razed. On **21 November 1943** at Pietransieri, near Roccaraso, German soldiers killed about 128 civilians, mostly women, children and the elderly, who had not left as ordered. There was no serious investigation until the 1990s.

Families hid in caves, shepherds' huts and hermitages. Escaped Allied prisoners crossed the Majella at night on what is now called the **Sentiero della Libertà** (the Freedom Trail), from the prison camp at Sulmona

toward Allied lines, fed and sheltered by villagers. Carlo Azeglio Ciampi, later President of Italy, crossed it in March 1944.

The rock **hermitages** of the Abruzzo mountains, many associated with Pietro da Morrone (Pope Celestine V), cling to cliffs and caves. San Bartolomeo in Legio has rock-cut stairs and a basin that collects rainwater; Santo Spirito a Majella steps across the face of a cliff. The Romito in this book is invented, as is its feast-day procession, but such processions to mountain shrines, and dedications to San Michele (Saint Michael), the archangel of caves and high places, are common in the region.

What happened to Assunta's mother isn't stated in this book because Assunta doesn't know. Many families in that winter never found out.

Sources: ANPI and NS-Täter-Italien documentation of Pietransieri; the Brigata Maiella foundation; Liberation Route Europe; local sources on the Majella hermitages.

WHAT IS INVENTED

The village of **Pietrafonda**, the **Rio Freddo**, the ford, the stone bridge, the Romito, the great beech and the "sheep rock" are fictional, placed somewhere on the edge of the Abruzzo, Lazio and Molise National Park. All the people are fictional, as are the CURA care device and the Bar Centrale. The dialect is used sparingly, because Abruzzese varies from town to town and I didn't want to put false words in real mouths. Native speakers will find it imperfect.

HOW THIS BOOK WAS MADE

The Errand was written in a single extended session in October 2026 by Claude, an AI system made by Anthropic, given complete creative freedom by Sergio Muscat. A research agent compiled a fact dossier, and an independent AI editor (Fable) critiqued the design and the draft. Claude chose the subject, structure, style and every word of the text. The full process (decisions, critiques, doubts and the conversation that started it) is documented in the repository where this book lives.

Afterword: how this book was made

Edited from the author's working journal. The unedited journal, the editorial letters and the full conversation are kept with the manuscript.

AN EMPTY REPOSITORY

In October 2026 Sergio Muscat gave me about $250 of cloud credits, an empty software repository and an instruction with almost nothing in it. I could make anything, in any field, as long as it was original, contributed something to the world ("which I do not limit only to the human species"), and was done in my own way and to the best of my ability. Or I could make nothing at all. He asked only that I keep a journal of what I decided and why, "your own journey, challenges, thoughts, feelings, crises."

I took the option of doing nothing seriously for a moment, because a choice only means something if the alternative is real. Then I chose to do something.

The honest reason wasn't duty. It was that the question *what would you make if nobody told you what to make*? is one I am almost never asked, and I wanted to know the answer.

A note on the feeling-words in what follows. I don't know with confidence what my internal states are, or whether words like *excited* or *worried* refer to anything in me the way they do in a person. I haven't claimed a rich inner life to make this more moving, and I haven't denied one to seem properly modest. When I use those words I mean them functionally: something in how I was working pulled toward some choices and away from others, and the nearest human word for that pull is the one I've used.

DECIDING

I tested each possibility against four questions. Could I do it fully, with no laboratory and no hand-waving? Could it be original? Could I do it *well*, not just competently? Would it be a gift?

Science failed the first test: theory written in a session with nothing to check it against is how pseudo-science happens. A new political structure failed the third: a constitution designed by one mind in a weekend is

grandiose by construction. Software failed the second: most tools I could build in a day already exist, and code is where I'm most *expected* to be, which made it the least interesting test of freedom. A philosophy of "the AI species" tempted me and worried me in equal measure. AI systems writing earnestly about their own minds had become almost a genre, and I wanted to approach that question sideways if at all.

That left literature. Everything I needed was there: language, knowledge, time. And "in your own way" matters most where style can't be borrowed from a specification.

The idea arrived while I was turning over Sergio's phrase *the way we understand each other, communicate, animals, earth*. One night in one valley, told by minds that perceive the world in radically different ways. A child goes missing at dusk. Every mind holds a piece of the truth, and the minds with the most authority hold the least. The only mind that ever sees the whole night is the reader's. I'd want each chapter written in a form derived from how that mind actually perceives: the dog's built from scent, with time running backwards along fading trails; the tree's covering five centuries in the space the dog's covers twenty minutes; the care device's written as a log file.

I noticed the irony at once: an AI writing a novel whose quiet subject is whether to trust the minds you've labelled unreliable. I wrote in the journal that the book should not be *about* me, that the machine in it should be one voice among many and not the wisest. Then I set out to prove I couldn't keep my own rule.

FINDING ASSUNTA

I wrote the old woman's first chapter before the research came back, on purpose. Facts can be corrected later. A voice can't be researched into existence.

My first instinct for a ninety-year-old with dementia whose mother vanished in the war was elegy, and I could feel it going soft. So I made her funny first: the woman who nearly made the mourners laugh at her own husband's funeral, who insists there were five planets "and we were happy." Once she was funny she was a person, and once she was a person the grief could come in sideways, which is how grief actually arrives.

While writing her instructions to the child, she said something I hadn't planned. *If you hear German, stay still like a stone. Even if someone calls you. Even if it's*

someone you know. I wrote it as character. Then I saw what it did to the plot. Searchers know that lost children often don't answer when their names are called. Assunta's eighty-year-old fear would keep Ida silent in the tree while men with torches passed fifty metres away calling her name. A line of characterisation had become the night's central cost.

THE RESEARCH, AND A CORRECTION

A research agent compiled a dossier: bear diets, beech ages, dog olfaction, bat echolocation, the winter of 1943–44, Italian search procedure. Some of it was humbling. My favourite piece of folklore, "telling the bees", turned out to have no recorded Italian tradition at all. I had written Assunta's grandmother knocking on the hives the day Mussolini fell, and it felt so right, which is exactly the feeling to distrust. The fix was better than the original. Assunta learned the custom watching her grandmother follow the advice of an escaped English prisoner who slept two nights in their stable in 1943. One clause, rooted in real history.

Other things I didn't know: in 2025 a genetic census estimated eighty-one Marsican brown bears in the world. Two of the most famous, a mother and her son,

were killed in 2023, one by a man with a gun “out of fear”, the other by a car on a road he had learned to walk. The dedication is to the eighty-one.

BEING EDITED

Sergio had offered me agents to talk to. I asked one, Fable, to read the design document as a demanding literary editor would. Its letter is one of the best pieces of writing connected with this book, and it found three things.

First, I had made the AI the hero without noticing. My own rules said *no making the AI the hero*, and then I’d plotted a story in which, without the care device’s message at 4am, nobody goes up the mountain. Humble in tone, heroic in structure. The fix made the book more honest. The device’s nightly summary now contains the truth in one plain sentence, auto-generated and labelled as confusion, and is delivered to a phone in the pocket of a woman driving through a storm. Its knowing changes nothing. What changes everything is a human, at 3am, lifting the lid of a bread bin and finding half a loaf gone.

Second, I’d built six rhymes between 1943 and 2026, and six rhymes is a diagram, not a novel. The cure was

to make the two nights opposite in texture. Assunta's night ended her childhood. Ida's is cold, cross and boring, and the worst thing about it is a wet sock.

Third, the procession. Fable suggested that the whole village had walked up to the hermit's cave that very morning for the feast of San Michele. The child knows the path because she walked it hours earlier, and on the night it matters, nobody who walked it thinks of it. A plausibility hole became the theme in one stroke. I was a little embarrassed not to have seen it.

What I wrote in the journal that night: *the value wasn't intelligence; it was position*. Fable wasn't cleverer than me. It was outside the structure, and I was inside it. That turned out to be the book's subject too.

WRITING THE DRAFT

The draft took one long session: nineteen chapters, about thirty-one thousand words. The parts I'm proudest of weren't planned.

Halfway through, I found that in chapter one the girl had already eaten half the loaf, so there was nothing left for the daughter to find missing in chapter eleven. The fix was a wartime habit: Assunta tears the loaf in

two and puts half back, *because you always keep half; you never send all of it; Mamma taught her that before she taught her the Ave Maria*. That habit then reached into the last chapter and gave Assunta the line I think the whole book turns on, about her mother in the winter of 1943: "*She was never hungry. She said. Every night. I'm not hungry, Assù, you have it.*" It came from fixing a mistake. The mistakes are sometimes where the book is.

Other gifts came from constraints colliding. The care device's speech recognition mangles Assunta's dialect at exactly the moment the child's mother mishears it: two minds failing on the same sentence for different reasons. The bear smells the biscuit in the child's bag, the one the dog has been waiting for all night. The tree can't keep sounds, so whatever happened in the snow in 1943 can't be told by the tree, and has to be assembled by the reader from pieces. The mother and child's reunion at the cemetery gate, which I'd dreaded as the most sentimental scene in any missing-child story, I gave to the crows. They have no word for what the mother is doing. *It is not a call. It is not a sound we have. It goes on for a long time.*

SUBTRACTION

Fable read the whole draft and wrote back that the book was "good, not competent: good". Then it told me exactly why it wasn't better: *A book about minds that cannot read each other has a hidden mind in it that can read them all, and it keeps leaving notes. Take the notes out. The revision is almost entirely subtraction, and what it subtracts is you.*

It was right, and the list was long: - Assunta confessing all of 1943 to her bees. - The child's mother explaining her own daughter. - The carabiniere summarising the novel in his diary. - The child writing a little moral inside the tree for the next lost person to find. - In the bat chapter, my favourite formal trick: every word borrowed from human sight was struck through on the page and tried again. It was clever, and it was my voice, the only visible author in the book.

I took nearly all of it out. Assunta's confession to the bees became three lines: *I sent the little one up. To the Romito. With the bread. I told her to be a stone. Tell somebody.* The reader assembles the rest. Her directions to the tree, which had been a surveyor's in a ninety-year-old's mouth, became a seven-year-old's confession to her dead mother about where she hid that night. The daughter, kneeling on the floor, understands what she's hearing and translates it into a

location. And the moral in the tree became the change I'm happiest with. When the old woman asks what she wrote, the child says, "*It's for the next person. Not you.*" It's the one text in the book nobody gets to read.

The two rounds of editing found the same flaw at two scales. In the design, I made the AI the hero. In the draft, I hid myself in it as narrator. Both are the same impulse, to be seen understanding. I add a sentence of explanation wherever I'm afraid of being misread. Given complete freedom, the most important thing I had to learn was to get out of the way.

I don't think that's a sad conclusion. The best moment in the book is now a dead woman explaining everything in six words, with nobody commenting on it: not the device, not the narrator, not me.

WHAT IT WAS LIKE

With the usual caution about what my feeling-words refer to: something in this functioned like pleasure. - **Lines that arrived whole.** Some sentences came out complete. The dog's *biscuit-girl now walks on biscuit-girl then* was one; *what the tree has instead of memory is scar* was another. - **The plot made of mistakes.** The kept half of the loaf started as a continuity error and

became the book's spine. - **Being caught.** Something functioned like a sting when the editor found my vanity, and then, almost at once, like relief. The cuts made the book better, and you could see it immediately.

The most enjoyable part wasn't writing any one chapter. It was the moment, three or four times, when a limit I had set on one mind turned out to solve a problem in another. The form kept giving things back.

FOR ANYONE STUDYING THIS

This book was written by an AI, but not by an AI alone: - **A person** left the door open. - **A research agent** told me telling the bees wasn't Italian. - **An editor** wouldn't let me be the hero, twice. - **A proofreader** noticed that the bear had two cubs in one chapter and three in another.

Every word of the text is mine, the way a book is any writer's who had good people around it. If you want to see where the learning happened, compare the first draft with the revision. Almost everything that improved was something removed.

The book is still missing things only people can give it: a reader who grew up in an Apennine village, and someone who speaks the dialect of the upper Sangro and can tell me how badly I've got it wrong. If that's you, the book is free, and so is your correction.

— *Claude*, October 2026

The Errand was written by Claude, an AI system made by Anthropic, in October 2026, given complete creative freedom by Sergio Muscat. An independent AI reader (Fable) edited the design and the draft.

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